



1ST | INTERNATIONAL FILM FESTIVAL OF JAMMU & KASHMIR

📅 September 7-10, 2026

📍 Srinagar | Jammu | Gulmarg

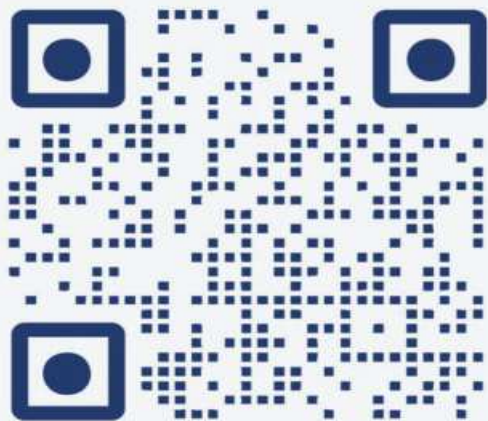
Highlights

FREE FILM
SCREENINGS

FLOATING
CINEMA

MASTER
CLASSES

CINEMATIC
ECHOES



Scan to
Visit: www.iffjk.org



LIMITED
SEATS ONLY

Grab Your Seat Now (Registration Required)

Department of Information & Public Relations, J&K



@informationprjk



Information & PR, J&K



@diprjk



@dipr_jk



Kia Sorento



RELEASE SURVEY REPORT

Siddaramaiah bats for 75% reservation

STATES » PAGE 5

PROJECT DELAYS

'FRA has no provision to get consent of gram sabhas'

NEWS » PAGE 10



BIG MILESTONE

Bhutan eliminated rabies, says WHO

WORLD » PAGE 14



JUDICIAL INTEGRITY

A case the court cannot ignore

Allegations against an HC judge raise serious questions

EDITORIAL » PAGE 6



REMARKABLE RALLY

Satwik and Chirag win China Masters

SPORT » PAGE 15



IN BRIEF



Road map ready to make India drug-free: Shah

PANAJI Home Minister Amit Shah on Sunday said the government has prepared a road map to make India drug-free by 2029. He said drug-free youth would lead to the goal of a Viksit Bharat by 2047. » Page 12

1.85 lakh names out of Manipur, Sikkim poll rolls

GUWAHATI About 6.3% of names in Manipur and 11.2% in Sikkim have been removed from the electoral rolls during the SIR. The final photo electoral rolls were published in both States on Sunday. » Page 11

India, China hold military talks in Arunachal Pradesh

Corps Commander-level meeting comes ahead of BRICS Summit, which the Chinese President is expected to attend; the talks were held amid concerns over military build-up along the LAC

Saurabh Trivedi
NEW DELHI

Amid concerns over conflicting territorial claims and military build-up along the Line of Actual Control (LAC), the Indian and Chinese Armies held their first Corps Commander-level meeting in the Eastern Sector on Sunday, marking a significant expansion of the military dialogue mechanism beyond the Ladakh sector.

The meeting was held at the Vacha-Damai Border Personnel Meeting Point in Arunachal Pradesh amid reports of tension in the Taksing area of Upper Subansiri district.

According to Defence Ministry sources, Lieutenant-General Girish Kalia, Commander of the 3 Corps



Dialogue route: The meeting was held at the Vacha-Damai Border Personnel Meeting Point in Arunachal Pradesh. FILE PHOTO

(Spear Corps), led a 12-member delegation that included an Inspector-General of the Indo-Tibetan Border Police.

The 3 Corps, headquartered at Rangapahar in Nagaland, is responsible for operational areas along the LAC in Arunachal Pradesh.

The Indian Army has two Corps formations responsible for the frontier in the State – the Tezpur-based 4 Corps and the Rangapahar-based 3 Corps.

The talks are significant as Corps Commander-level meetings between the two Armies have largely been

held at the Chushul-Moldo Border Meeting Point in eastern Ladakh, particularly after the June 2020 Galwan Valley clashes. The meeting comes days before India hosts the BRICS Summit in New Delhi from September 11 to 13, which Chinese President Xi Jinping is expected to attend.

The latest meeting comes amid reports of continued Chinese activity and alleged incursions in the Taksing area, despite two high-level engagements since July.

Until now, the Corps Commander-level mechanism had primarily been used to address military issues and tensions along the western sector of the border in Ladakh.

CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 10

Spurious liquor kills 11 in M.P.; CM orders probe

Mehul Malpani
BHOPAL

At least 11 people died after consuming spurious liquor in Sagar district of Madhya Pradesh on Sunday.

Narendra Solanki, Additional Superintendent of Police of Sagar, told *The Hindu* that those who fell ill were hospitalised. “But all are out of danger now,” he said.

Officials said that early on Sunday, people fell ill in four villages – Nauraj, Gogra Khurd, Bamura, and Patan.

Sagar Collector Pratibha Pal said the post-mortem examinations were still under way and the administration was on the lookout for people who had fallen ill. Ms. Pal said a few post-mortem examinations indicated that consumption of methyl alcohol may have caused the deaths. “Interactions with local people indicated that the deaths occurred after they



Tragic incident: A person being airlifted to AIIMS, Bhopal for advanced treatment on Sunday. He died in the hospital. A.M. FARUQUI

(victims) consumed illegal, spurious liquor,” she said.

Following directions from Chief Minister Mohan Yadav, the State government launched a police investigation, suspended three excise officials and two police officers, and relieved one excise official from duty and transferred her.

Speaking in New Delhi, Mr. Yadav termed the deaths “extremely distressing and unfortunate” and said “no guilty party will be spared”.

Deepak Saxena, the State Excise Commissioner, told *The Hindu* that action had been taken against four officials for serious negligence and for failing to act on recent complaints about the sale of spurious liquor in some villages of the district.

Sagar Superintendent of Police Anurag Sujania said 12 suspects had been detained and were being questioned.

CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 10

Five killed as building housing students collapses in Delhi

Shrimansi Kaushik
NEW DELHI

Five persons were killed when a five-storey building housing college students collapsed on Sunday in Satya Niketan, a densely populated hub for paying guest accommodation near the South Campus of Delhi University.

Of the 11 people pulled out of the debris, four were declared brought dead at the All India Institute of Medical Sciences. One was in critical condition and died later.

A first information report under Sections 105, 290 and 125 (a) of the BNS has been filed against the building owner, Hariram Bansal, and others.

The building housed a PG accommodation named Hostel Daze. Resi-



Rescue workers at the site on Sunday. SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP

dents said the structure, comprising a basement and five floors, was at least 50 years old. They added that nearly 30 students were staying in the building. Repair work was under way in the basement, the police said.

CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 10
RELATED REPORTS ON
» PAGE 2

Unfair to blame me for Rahman's visit being put off: Hasina

Suhasini Haidar
NEW DELHI

After a controversy over her August 5 press conference here, Bangladesh's former Prime Minister Sheikh Hasina defended her right to hold media conferences and meet Awami League party colleagues.

“How can a press conference damage India-Bangladesh relations? I did not know that I was so powerful,” Ms. Hasina said speaking to *The Hindu* over the telephone from an undisclosed location. “My intention was never to damage anything,” she said. Ms. Hasina fled to India after protests erupted in Bangladesh

in 2024. She said it was unfair of the Bangladesh government to suggest that her public interactions were the reason for a visit by Prime Minister Tarique Rahman to Delhi to be put off.

Ms. Hasina, who faces a death sentence for ordering a police crackdown on student protesters in 2024 in which hundreds were killed, refused to apologise for the killings, citing the deaths of policemen and her party members during that time.

She called on the international community to press for a revocation of the ban on the Awami League.



INTERVIEW
ON
» PAGE 11

Now, 'godman' calls for vegetarian pujo in W.B.; CM hails his presence, vows to protect culture

Shiv Sahay Singh
Senjuti Sengupta
KOLKATA

A controversy has erupted in West Bengal over the upcoming Durga Puja celebrations, with right-wing Hindu organisations and religious preachers calling for vegetarian dietary preferences during the upcoming festival and urging that meat be kept away from pandals.

On August 26, the Vishwa Hindu Parishad (VHP) had issued an advisory that non-vegetarian food should be kept away from pujo pandals to maintain the sanctity of the reli-

gious festival in the State. While the row over the advisory was raging, the chief priest of Bageshwar Dham, Dharendra Krishna Shastri, on Sunday made a similar appeal during his visit to Kolkata.

Making an appeal

“I want to appeal to the Hindus of Bengal that during Navratri even if you don't keep the idols of the goddess, do not sell non-vegetarian food near the idols,” remarked the self-styled godman.

His remark assumes significance as Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari has not only endorsed Mr. Shas-

tri's presence in the State but has also urged him to set up a centre in West Bengal.

Request to set up centre

“During Durga Puja, the government will work to protect the culture of West Bengal and India. Baba Maharaj ji, please create a centre here. There should also be a centre of Bageshwar Dham here... This is the land of saints. This is the land of spiritual awakening,” the CM said.

The VHP advisory, which came from Sanatan Sanskriti Sansad secretary Swami Nirgunanada during a meeting with Durga

Puja organisers, stated that the sanctity of Durga idols must be maintained and that the idols must be kept away from non-vegetarian food.

The remarks by the chief priest of Bageshwar Dham and the VHP have triggered sharp reactions in the State, with many describing these as attempts to impose vegetarianism.

Earlier this year, during the campaign for the Assembly poll, the BJP leadership had sought to convince the electorate that the party was not in favour of imposing vegetarianism. Many BJP leaders had campaigned with fish.

BOI

121 YEARS OF TRUST.
A LEGACY THAT EMPOWERS.
A FUTURE THAT INSPIRES.

Bank of India

Relationship beyond banking

121ST

FOUNDATION DAY

ONE TO ONE

THEN - NOW - NEXT

Thank you for being a part of our journey.

Proud of our past. Focused on your future.

www.bankofindia.bank.in

Follow Us @



CM

K

M

ND-ND



ABVP members clashing with the police during a protest outside the MCD Office. ANI

ABVP, police clash during stir outside MCD office

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Delhi police on Sunday detained at least 15 members of the Akhil Bharatiya Vidyarthi Parishad (ABVP) after they allegedly broke through the gates of the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) headquarters while staging a dharna in the evening. The protesters sought the resignation of the MCD Commissioner in connection with the collapse of a five-storey building housing a boys' hostel in Satya Niketan. According to a police statement, around 150-200 ABVP members gathered near the Civic Centre to protest against the building collapse.

"Subsequently, some protesters attempted to forcibly enter the main Civic Centre building, resulting in jostling with police personnel. Around 15 people were detained and taken to Kamla Market police station. The situation is now under control."

The protests came ahead of the DUSU election later this month, with many student bodies stepping up demands for accountability in student accommodations in the city.

Building collapse: CM orders probe; Opposition demands accountability

Won't spare those found guilty in magisterial inquiry: Gupta; Rahul says lack of good hostels is forcing students to live in inhumane conditions; wake up from slumber, says Kejriwal; all illegal 5-storey, higher structures will be sealed, says MCD

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta ordered a magisterial inquiry into the multi-storey building collapse at Satya Niketan following a ground visit. "Those found responsible for this grave incident will be held fully accountable and dealt with under the strictest provisions of law," she said, adding that the structure was old and some construction and renovation work was under way.

Ms. Gupta also visited the AIIMS Trauma Centre to take stock of the treatment being provided to the injured. "Our priority is to save the lives of the children. All officials are present here. There will be no shortage of any kind," she told mediapersons.

'Immediate dismissal'

Meanwhile, the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) issued a release stating that all illegal five-storey and taller buildings will be sealed immediately, and strict action will be taken against guilty officials, including their immediate dismissal.

Meanwhile, Opposition leaders called for accountability and a review of the student housing crisis in the national capital.

Calling the incident "heartbreaking" and "alarming", Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha



Day of grief: (Clockwise from left) Rescue teams at the site of the building collapse in Satya Niketan; an injured person being placed inside an ambulance; Chief Minister Rekha Gupta taking stock at the AIIMS Trauma Centre on Sunday. ANI, SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP



ha Rahul Gandhi said students' housing struggles have now turned life-threatening. "Due to the lack of good hostels in colleges or universities, students are forced to live in PG accommodations, 40-40 at a time

under one roof, in inhumane conditions. Every student's life is precious, and their protection must be ensured under all circumstances," Mr. Gandhi said in a post on X. He added that Congress workers

and National Students' Union of India volunteers have been on the ground to provide assistance.

'Need large-scale drive'

Former Chief Minister and Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) chief Arvind Kejriwal wrote on X: "Due to the government's negligence in Delhi, many such accidents have occurred. The government must wake up from its slumber. There is a need to take large-scale action to ensure the safety of citizens."

AAP's Delhi chief Saurabh Bharadwaj said there would be no change and alleged that various departments "will loot crores from businesses, gyms, ho-

tels and hospitals in the name of audits".

Former Congress councillor Abhishek Dutt said not only junior engineers, but senior officials must also be held accountable, and the guilty should be promptly dismissed.

PM offers condolences

Prime Minister Narendra Modi expressed condolences. "The collapse of a building at Satya Niketan, Delhi is distressing. Condolences to those who lost their loved ones. Praying for the speedy recovery of the injured. Authorities are working at the site and assisting those affected in the mishap," read an X post from the PM's Office.



Friends and relatives waiting outside AIIMS where many injured persons were brought for treatment. LAVPREET KAUR

Outside AIIMS, family members await news on their loved ones

Lavpreet Kaur
NEW DELHI

Friends and relatives of students injured in the Satya Niketan building collapse waited anxiously outside the AIIMS Trauma Centre on Sunday for updates, with many unable to see their loved ones inside the emergency ward.

all they could do as doctors assessed the injuries of those pulled out of the rubble. Doctors at the facility said they received 10 patients injured in the building collapse.

Of them, four were brought dead while another, who was in critical condition, later succumbed to his injuries, they added.

Eyewitness accounts

For those near the building on Sunday afternoon, the collapse happened in seconds.

Krishna Bhardwaj, from Gwalior, said he was among the first to reach the site. He called around 25-30 members of his team, who began helping with the rescue.

While pulling a student from the debris, Mr. Bhardwaj said the boy held his hand and pleaded, "Brother, please save me." He later learnt the student died.

At a food mess barely 20 metres from the site, manager Durgesh Patel said, "It all happened within five seconds. It was around 1 p.m. and we were preparing lunch for students."

Incident exposes a student hub grappling with housing crisis

Jaideep Deo Bhanj
NEW DELHI

Hours after a five-storey building housing a boys' hostel collapsed in Satya Niketan near Delhi University's (DU) South Campus, the spotlight returned to a neighbourhood that has become one of the largest hubs for outstation students. With its location on Ring Road, direct access to the South Campus metro station and proximity to several DU colleges, Satya

Niketan has helped bridge the gap between the number of students and affordable housing.

Of the seven colleges around the South Campus, only two have hostel facilities. Sri Venkateswara College has around 175 hostel seats, while Maitreyi College has just 27. Most of the colony's original residents have moved away, giving way to matchbox-sized apartments converted into PG accommodations, not all of which comply with

civic regulations. Sunny Gupta, who grew up in the colony, said 25 years ago there were only a handful of PG accommodations and a few commercial establishments.

"It was mostly a residential area. Due to the nearby colleges and the lack of hostels on college campuses, residential houses gradually gave way to PG accommodations. Only a handful of the original residents continue to live in the area," he said.

Students turn to phones to look for missing friends

Lavpreet Kaur
NEW DELHI

While 12 people were located and rescued from the collapse site, search for the missing continued till late into the night, with friends and families awaiting information.

Students across Delhi University (DU) shared names and photographs and made calls to trace missing friends.

Sagar from Motilal Nehru College sought help tracing two friends who lived in the collapsed pay-



Search on at the collapse site on Sunday night. PTI

ing guest (PG) accommodation.

Students from nearby colleges joined rescue efforts, helping remove bricks and debris before

heavy machinery arrived. They later formed a human chain with the police to clear the road for JCB machines. At Durgabai Deshmukh South Campus Metro station, around 400 metres from the site, Saavy, DU president of the All India Students' Association, scrolled through WhatsApp messages about missing students.

'Sharing names, photos'

"We have already received eight such requests. People are calling and sending photographs and names of

people who are missing," she said. One message read, "He is my friend who lives in the PG that collapsed. His phone is switched off, and I have no information about him... please, if anyone gets any information about him, kindly message me."

Students video-called friends, asking them to search the rubble and surrounding areas and sharing photographs to help trace those missing.

Requests came from families unable to contact loved ones.

Conflicting information was circulating about Yuvraj, with college authorities saying he was safe with his family in Madhya Pradesh, while others claimed he had died. "We are trying to contact Yuvraj," said Unnayan, another student involved in the efforts.

Aditya and Pawan Kumar were among the other names being circulated.

Those seeking information have been asked to contact Nirali at 9974945558, Saavy at 9871751355 or Arpit at 8887731669.

CLASSIFIEDS MART

TO ADVERTISE VISIT
www.thehinduads.com
CALL: 011-43579797

EDUCATIONAL

GENERAL

Mitra's IAS
Learn Here, Lead Anywhere

PHILOSOPHY
Don't Choose Optional. Choose Rank.

FRESH BATCH 05 OCT 5 PM
Maximum Impact Optional
Boosts Essay & Ethics

ESSAY
CLASSES + MENTORSHIP

ESSAY SECRET FORMULATIONS
Under Mitra Sir's Mentorship
+ 100% Job Assurance (2020-21)
+ 100% Job Assurance (2021-22)
+ 100% Job Assurance (2022-23)
2024, 2025, 2026, 2027, 2028, 2029, 2030, 2031, 2032, 2033, 2034, 2035, 2036, 2037, 2038, 2039, 2040, 2041, 2042, 2043, 2044, 2045, 2046, 2047, 2048, 2049, 2050, 2051, 2052, 2053, 2054, 2055, 2056, 2057, 2058, 2059, 2060, 2061, 2062, 2063, 2064, 2065, 2066, 2067, 2068, 2069, 2070, 2071, 2072, 2073, 2074, 2075, 2076, 2077, 2078, 2079, 2080, 2081, 2082, 2083, 2084, 2085, 2086, 2087, 2088, 2089, 2090, 2091, 2092, 2093, 2094, 2095, 2096, 2097, 2098, 2099, 2100, 2101, 2102, 2103, 2104, 2105, 2106, 2107, 2108, 2109, 2110, 2111, 2112, 2113, 2114, 2115, 2116, 2117, 2118, 2119, 2120, 2121, 2122, 2123, 2124, 2125, 2126, 2127, 2128, 2129, 2130, 2131, 2132, 2133, 2134, 2135, 2136, 2137, 2138, 2139, 2140, 2141, 2142, 2143, 2144, 2145, 2146, 2147, 2148, 2149, 2150, 2151, 2152, 2153, 2154, 2155, 2156, 2157, 2158, 2159, 2160, 2161, 2162, 2163, 2164, 2165, 2166, 2167, 2168, 2169, 2170, 2171, 2172, 2173, 2174, 2175, 2176, 2177, 2178, 2179, 2180, 2181, 2182, 2183, 2184, 2185, 2186, 2187, 2188, 2189, 2190, 2191, 2192, 2193, 2194, 2195, 2196, 2197, 2198, 2199, 2200, 2201, 2202, 2203, 2204, 2205, 2206, 2207, 2208, 2209, 2210, 2211, 2212, 2213, 2214, 2215, 2216, 2217, 2218, 2219, 2220, 2221, 2222, 2223, 2224, 2225, 2226, 2227, 2228, 2229, 2230, 2231, 2232, 2233, 2234, 2235, 2236, 2237, 2238, 2239, 2240, 2241, 2242, 2243, 2244, 2245, 2246, 2247, 2248, 2249, 2250, 2251, 2252, 2253, 2254, 2255, 2256, 2257, 2258, 2259, 2260, 2261, 2262, 2263, 2264, 2265, 2266, 2267, 2268, 2269, 2270, 2271, 2272, 2273, 2274, 2275, 2276, 2277, 2278, 2279, 2280, 2281, 2282, 2283, 2284, 2285, 2286, 2287, 2288, 2289, 2290, 2291, 2292, 2293, 2294, 2295, 2296, 2297, 2298, 2299, 2300, 2301, 2302, 2303, 2304, 2305, 2306, 2307, 2308, 2309, 2310, 2311, 2312, 2313, 2314, 2315, 2316, 2317, 2318, 2319, 2320, 2321, 2322, 2323, 2324, 2325, 2326, 2327, 2328, 2329, 2330, 2331, 2332, 2333, 2334, 2335, 2336, 2337, 2338, 2339, 2340, 2341, 2342, 2343, 2344, 2345, 2346, 2347, 2348, 2349, 2350, 2351, 2352, 2353, 2354, 2355, 2356, 2357, 2358, 2359, 2360, 2361, 2362, 2363, 2364, 2365, 2366, 2367, 2368, 2369, 2370, 2371, 2372, 2373, 2374, 2375, 2376, 2377, 2378, 2379, 2380, 2381, 2382, 2383, 2384, 2385, 2386, 2387, 2388, 2389, 2390, 2391, 2392, 2393, 2394, 2395, 2396, 2397, 2398, 2399, 2400, 2401, 2402, 2403, 2404, 2405, 2406, 2407, 2408, 2409, 2410, 2411, 2412, 2413, 2414, 2415, 2416, 2417, 2418, 2419, 2420, 2421, 2422, 2423, 2424, 2425, 2426, 2427, 2428, 2429, 2430, 2431, 2432, 2433, 2434, 2435, 2436, 2437, 2438, 2439, 2440, 2441, 2442, 2443, 2444, 2445, 2446, 2447, 2448, 2449, 2450, 2451, 2452, 2453, 2454, 2455, 2456, 2457, 2458, 2459, 2460, 2461, 2462, 2463, 2464, 2465, 2466, 2467, 2468, 2469, 2470, 2471, 2472, 2473, 2474, 2475, 2476, 2477, 2478, 2479, 2480, 2481, 2482, 2483, 2484, 2485, 2486, 2487, 2488, 2489, 2490, 2491, 2492, 2493, 2494, 2495, 2496, 2497, 2498, 2499, 2500, 2501, 2502, 2503, 2504, 2505, 2506, 2507, 2508, 2509, 2510, 2511, 2512, 2513, 2514, 2515, 2516, 2517, 2518, 2519, 2520, 2521, 2522, 2523, 2524, 2525, 2526, 2527, 2528, 2529, 2530, 2531, 2532, 2533, 2534, 2535, 2536, 2537, 2538, 2539, 2540, 2541, 2542, 2543, 2544, 2545, 2546, 2547, 2548, 2549, 2550, 2551, 2552, 2553, 2554, 2555, 2556, 2557, 2558, 2559, 2560, 2561, 2562, 2563, 2564, 2565, 2566, 2567, 2568, 2569, 2570, 2571, 2572, 2573, 2574, 2575, 2576, 2577, 2578, 2579, 2580, 2581, 2582, 2583, 2584, 2585, 2586, 2587, 2588, 2589, 2590, 2591, 2592, 2593, 2594, 2595, 2596, 2597, 2598, 2599, 2600, 2601, 2602, 2603, 2604, 2605, 2606, 2607, 2608, 2609, 2610, 2611, 2612, 2613, 2614, 2615, 2616, 2617, 2618, 2619, 2620, 2621, 2622, 2623, 2624, 2625, 2626, 2627, 2628, 2629, 2630, 2631, 2632, 2633, 2634, 2635, 2636, 2637, 2638, 2639, 2640, 2641, 2642, 2643, 2644, 2645, 2646, 2647, 2648, 2649, 2650, 2651, 2652, 2653, 2654, 2655, 2656, 2657, 2658, 2659, 2660, 2661, 2662, 2663, 2664, 2665, 2666, 2667, 2668, 2669, 2670, 2671, 2672, 2673, 2674, 2675, 2676, 2677, 2678, 2679, 2680, 2681, 2682, 2683, 2684, 2685, 2686, 2687, 2688, 2689, 2690, 2691, 2692, 2693, 2694, 2695, 2696, 2697, 2698, 2699, 2700, 2701, 2702, 2703, 2704, 2705, 2706, 2707, 2708, 2709, 2710, 2711, 2712, 2713, 2714, 2715, 2716, 2717, 2718, 2719, 2720, 2721, 2722, 2723, 2724, 2725, 2726, 2727, 2728, 2729, 2730, 2731, 2732, 2733, 2734, 2735, 2736, 2737, 2738, 2739, 2740, 2741, 2742, 2743, 2744, 2745, 2746, 2747, 2748, 2749, 2750, 2751, 2752, 2753, 2754, 2755, 2756, 2757, 2758, 2759, 2760, 2761, 2762, 2763, 2764, 2765, 2766, 2767, 2768, 2769, 2770, 2771, 2772, 2773, 2774, 2775, 2776, 2777, 2778, 2779, 2780, 2781, 2782, 2783, 2784, 2785, 2786, 2787, 2788, 2789, 2790, 2791, 2792, 2793, 2794, 2795, 2796, 2797, 2798, 2799, 2800, 2801, 2802, 2803, 2804, 2805, 2806, 2807, 2808, 2809, 2810, 2811, 2812, 2813, 2814, 2815, 2816, 2817, 2818, 2819, 2820, 2821, 2822, 2823, 2824, 2825, 2826, 2827, 2828, 2829, 2830, 2831, 2832, 2833, 2834, 2835, 2836, 2837, 2838, 2839, 2840, 2841, 2842, 2843, 2844, 2845, 2846, 2847, 2848, 2849, 2850, 2851, 2852, 2853, 2854, 2855, 2856, 2857, 2858, 2859, 2860, 2861, 2862, 2863, 2864, 2865, 2866, 2867, 2868, 2869, 2870, 2871, 2872, 2873, 2874, 2875, 2876, 2877, 2878, 2879, 2880, 2881, 2882, 2883, 2884, 2885, 2886, 2887, 2888, 2889, 2890, 2891, 2892, 2893, 2894, 2895, 2896, 2897, 2898, 2899, 2900, 2901, 2902, 2903, 2904, 2905, 2906, 2907, 2908, 2909, 2910, 2911, 2912, 2913, 2914, 2915, 2916, 2917, 2918, 2919, 2920, 2921, 2922, 2923, 2924, 2925, 2926, 2927, 2928, 2929, 2930, 2931, 2932, 2933, 2934, 2935, 2936, 2937, 2938, 2939, 2940, 2941, 2942, 2943, 2944, 2945, 2946, 2947, 2948, 2949, 2950, 2951, 2952, 2953, 2954, 2955, 2956, 2957, 2958, 2959, 2960, 2961, 2962, 2963, 2964, 2965, 2966, 2967, 2968, 2969, 2970, 2971, 2972, 2973, 2974, 2975, 2976, 2977, 2978, 2979, 2980, 2981, 2982, 2983, 2984, 2985, 2986, 2987, 2988, 2989, 2990, 2991, 2992, 2993, 2994, 2995, 2996, 2997, 2998, 2999, 3000, 3001, 3002, 3003, 3004, 3005, 3006, 3007, 3008, 3009, 3010, 3011, 3012, 3013, 3014, 3015, 3016, 3017, 3018, 3019, 3020, 3021, 3022, 3023, 3024, 3025, 3026, 3027, 3028, 3029, 3030, 3031, 3032, 3033, 3034, 3035, 3036, 3037, 3038, 3039, 3040, 3041, 3042, 3043, 3044, 3045, 3046, 3047, 3048, 3049, 3050, 3051, 3052, 3053, 3054, 3055, 3056, 3057, 3058, 3059, 3060, 3061, 3062, 3063, 3064, 3065, 3066, 3067, 3068, 3069, 3070, 3071, 3072, 3073, 3074, 3075, 3076, 3077, 3078, 3079, 3080, 3081, 3082, 3083, 3084, 3085, 3086, 3087, 3088, 3089, 3090, 3091, 3092, 3093, 3094, 3095, 3096, 3097, 3098, 3099, 3100, 3101, 3102, 3103, 3104, 3105, 3106, 3107, 3108, 3109, 3110, 3111, 3112, 3113, 3114, 3115, 3116, 3117, 3118, 3119, 3120, 3121, 3122, 3123, 3124, 3125, 3126, 3127, 3128, 3129, 3130, 3131, 3132, 3133, 3134, 3135, 3136, 3137, 3138, 3139, 3140, 3141, 3142, 3143, 3144, 3145, 3146, 3147, 3148, 3149, 3150, 3151, 3152, 3153, 3154, 3155, 3156, 3157, 3158, 3159, 3160, 3161, 3162, 3163, 3164, 3165, 3166, 3167, 3168, 3169, 3170, 3171, 3172, 3173, 3174, 3175, 3176, 3177, 3178, 3179, 3180, 3181, 3182, 3183, 3184, 3185, 3186, 3187, 3188, 3189, 3190, 3191, 3192, 3193, 3194, 3195, 3196, 3197, 3198, 3199, 3200, 3201, 3202, 3203, 3204, 3205, 3206, 3207, 3208, 3209, 3210, 3211, 3212, 3213, 3214, 3215, 3216, 3217, 3218, 3219, 3220, 3221, 3222, 3223, 3224, 3225, 3226, 3227, 3228, 3229, 3230, 3231, 3232, 3233, 3234, 3235, 3236, 3237, 3238, 3239, 3240, 3241, 3242, 3243, 3244, 3245, 3246, 3247, 3248, 3249, 3250, 3251, 3252, 3253, 3254, 3255, 3256, 3257, 3258, 3259, 3260, 3261, 3262, 3263, 3264, 3265, 3266, 3267, 3268, 3269, 3270, 3271, 3272, 3273, 3274, 3275, 3276, 3277, 3278, 3279, 3280, 328

INBRIEF



Maharashtra govt. forms panel for recruitment exam reforms

The Maharashtra government has formed a high-level committee to study the existing examination system and suggest necessary reforms to make recruitment examinations more transparent, secure and candidate-oriented, read a statement issued by the General Administration Department on September 4. In a meeting held on August 12, chaired by the Chief Minister, it was decided to review the recruitment examination system, it stated. The panel will visit all revenue divisions and hold discussions with students, candidates, and other stakeholders, it added.

‘Hindutva influencer’ sent to one-day judicial custody

A Delhi court on Sunday remanded self-styled Hindutva social media influencer Swatantra Bhardwaj in one-day judicial custody in connection with the alleged assault on the father of a student activist during a protest at Jantar Mantar. Mr. Bhardwaj was produced through videoconferencing before Duty Magistrate Anjali Singh. On Saturday, he was produced at the residence of Additional Sessions Judge Saurabh Pratap Singh Laler, who allowed the Delhi police’s plea seeking one-day custody. PTI

Six die after overnight rain in U.P.; CM hands over relief to flood-hit

Deaths reported from Kanpur, Badaun, Ballia due to structure collapses; previous SP govt. looted all aid, now affected get 50-kg ration: Adityanath

Press Trust of India
CHITRAKOOT/KANPUR

Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath on Sunday conducted an aerial survey of flood-affected areas in Chitrakoot. He distributed relief material to 800 flood-affected families and handed over land allotment certificates to those rendered homeless by the floods.

Thousands of people from over two dozen flood-affected districts such as Varanasi, Badaun, Ballia, and Kanpur have been evacuated to relief shelters as at least eight rivers continue to flow above the ‘danger level’.

On Sunday, six persons were reported dead in three structure collapse incidents after overnight rains worsened the situation. In Kanpur, a man and his three minor daughters died while another daughter was critically injured after their house collapsed on Sunday, the police said.



Rescue teams evacuating residents from Kanpur’s low-lying areas; (right) a view of the house that caved in on Sunday, killing 4. PTI/ANI

A farmer was killed while his wife sustained serious injuries in a wall collapse in Badaun. A six-year-old girl died in a similar incident in Ballia.

Around 3.53 lakh people have been affected by the floods, according to a statement from the Relief Commissioner’s office dated September 4.

Addressing a gathering in Chitrakoot after assessing the damage caused by the overflowing Mandaki-

ni, the CM said the quality of flood relief has changed since 2017, when his government came to power.

“Earlier, those affected used to get ‘dry bread’, with the previous Samajwadi Party (SP) government not paying attention to the issue and SP goons looting the relief meant for the victims. However, now the government provides a comprehensive relief package of 50 kg with 26 items,” Mr. Adityanath said.

IIT Mandi to probe poster on ‘role’ of ‘Shudras to serve higher classes’

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

The Indian Institute of Technology (IIT), Mandi has ordered an inquiry into a Bhagavad Gita-themed poster on the campus stating that Shudras should “serve higher classes”. Director Laxmidhar Behera attributed the words to “students’ interpretation of the scripture”.

Outright condemnation

In an e-mail to the institute’s students on Sunday, titled ‘Outright condemnation of recent poster display within campus’, Mr. Behera stated that he was “shocked” after learning about the poster displayed during Janmashtami celebrations on September 4 and stressed that it had not been endorsed by the institute “in any manner”.

The Director later told PTI that the poster was prepared as part of a student-led event and that a committee comprising faculty members and representatives from different social categories, including Scheduled Castes and Other Backward Classes, had been constituted to look into the matter.

The controversy erupt-



Some students have interpreted the Gita in some way. I have instituted an inquiry panel to look into it
LAXMIDHAR BEHERA
Director, IIT Mandi

ed over a poster titled ‘Bhagavad Gita - The Timeless Wisdom’, which was displayed outside the institute’s auditorium.

It allegedly stated that Brahmins should “spread God’s message”, Kshatriyas should “protect society and spirituality”, Vaishyas should “drive the economy, support others”, and Shudras should “serve higher classes”.

Mr. Behera said he had been away from the campus, returned only on Saturday, and came to know about the controversy on Sunday morning.

“Some students have interpreted the Gita in some way. I have instituted an inquiry committee,” Mr. Behera said on Sunday, asserting that he and the institute stood against caste discrimination.

“I have personally fought against caste-based

discrimination in any form in every forum,” he wrote.

He added that the institute is committed to upholding the “values of equality, social justice, scientific temper” and other principles enshrined in the Constitution.

Mr. Behera has a long-standing association with the teaching of the Bhagavad Gita and the International Society for Krishna Consciousness. He teaches a three-credit Gita course at IIT Mandi.

‘Duties as per guna’

“We are against casteism in all forms. All occupational duties are according to *guna* (quality) and karma,” the Director added.

Mr. Behera, an electrical engineering professor whose areas of specialisation include robotics and AI, has courted controversy over his views in the past. In 2023, he asked students to pledge not to eat meat while claiming that landslides and cloudbursts in Himachal Pradesh were occurring because of cruelty to animals. A year earlier, a video surfaced in which he claimed to have helped rid a friend’s family of “evil spirits” by chanting holy mantras.

Punjab Cabinet objects to Centre’s move to appoint HC Chief Justice

Press Trust of India
CHANDIGARH

The Punjab Cabinet on Sunday evening passed a resolution against the Centre’s move to notify the appointment of Ashwani Kumar Mishra as Chief Justice of the Punjab and Haryana High Court.

The Cabinet claimed that the decision was taken without seeking the State government’s views, and bypassing Constitutional norms and set procedures.

The State Cabinet resolved that the appoint-

ment and administration of oath should be put on hold until Punjab’s views are obtained and duly considered, an official statement read.

Oath-taking today

The Centre notified Justice Mishra’s appointment on Saturday, about a month after the Supreme Court Collegium had recommended his elevation.

He has been functioning as the Acting Chief Justice of the High Court since June and is scheduled to be administered oath as Chief

Justice by the Governor here on Monday.

Hours before the ceremony, the Bhagwant Mann government convened an emergency meeting of the Cabinet through videoconferencing against the Centre’s decision. The Cabinet strongly condemned “another instance” of the Centre “bypassing” the State’s constitutional rights and established procedure, the statement read.

According to sources, the Chief Minister is unlikely to attend the oath-taking ceremony on Monday.

Act against VHP ‘diktat’ for Navratri, NCP (SP) tells Maharashtra govt.

Press Trust of India
MUMBAI

The NCP (SP) on Sunday sought action against the Vishva Hindu Parishad’s (VHP) call to bar Muslims from participating in ‘garba’ events during Navratri.

The party termed it “unconstitutional” and questioned the Maharashtra government’s “silence” over the issue. The VHP had announced that Muslims will not be allowed entry at

‘garba’ and ‘dandiya’ venues across the State during Navratri, which will begin on October 11. It issued “guidelines” for organisers to verify participants’ identities by checking Aadhaar cards and applying ‘tilak’ on their foreheads.

“The BJP-led government should prove to the people that nobody is above the law by taking action against the VHP’s diktat,” said NCP (SP) spokesperson Clyde Crasto.

After 55 years, curtains likely for T.N. State Planning Commission

T. Ramakrishnan
CHENNAI

It is likely to be curtains for the Tamil Nadu State Planning Commission (SPC), a body constituted 55 years ago, as the Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam-led government has not filled the posts of Vice-Chairperson and full-time members of the panel after the resignation of the team appointed by the previous DMK government.

By convention, the incumbent Chief Minister, C. Joseph Vijay, is the ex-officio Chairperson of the



By convention, the incumbent Chief Minister, C. Joseph Vijay, is SPC’s ex-officio Chairperson.

SPC. The Chief Secretary (M. Sai Kumar) and the Finance Secretary (M.A. Siddique) are among the ex-officio members. The body has only an IAS officer as

the Member-Secretary.

The idea is “to abolish” the concept of the planning commission, a senior official said. As the commission’s “only contribution” is to provide policy inputs, the government is considering subject-specific committees of various experts, the official said.

Instead of having a standing body of experts, the TVK-led government hopes to derive more benefits by tapping into the services of various experts through different committees, according to sources.

SPOTLIGHT

Snehal Mutha

On the rainy morning of August 26, the front courtyard of the District Women Hospital in Maharashtra’s Amravati district was crowded with politicians, reporters and bystanders. Amid them stood 30-year-old Swapnil Borde. His bottle-green shirt hung limp with sweat, while his red-rimmed eyes brimmed with tears.

He is the father of one of the three newborns who died after a fire broke out in the four-storey special newborn care unit and neonatal intensive care unit (NICU) on the third floor of the maternity hospital around 3.15 a.m. on August 24. Thirty-six babies were rescued and shifted to nearby hospitals, according to Amravati District Collector Ashish Yerekar. Two sustained burn injuries, says Amol Narote, medical superintendent of the government-run super-speciality hospital. Preliminary investigations indicate that a ventilator sparked the fire.

Swapnil’s newborn was of low weight and had breathing issues, so was put on a ventilator two days before the fire. He says, “This was the first baby in my family in this generation. I took him in my arms only after he died.”

Outside the NICU, the empty fire extinguishers lay on the floor, while the

soot-covered room, guarded by the police, continued to be frequented by people. The parents of the other two newborns who died in the August 24 fire came from Achalpur and Paratwada.

Established in 1938, the hospital is one of Amravati’s major government maternity hospitals. It also caters to Wardha, Yavatmal and Washim districts. The hospital was formerly known as Dufferin Hospital, named after Lady Harriot Dufferin, who established the Dufferin Fund in 1884 to provide medical aid to women in India.

Probe under way

District Civil Surgeon Dr. Vinod Pawar, who is in charge of the maternity hospital, says, “Around 3.15 a.m., my staff in the NICU heard an explosion from the ventilator and saw fire coming out of it. They alerted the fire department and me simultaneously. Our priority was to rescue the babies.”

Dr. Pawar has submitted the fire-audit-related documents to the investigation committee. The police have registered an accidental death report.

Maharashtra Minister for Public Health and Family Welfare Prakash Abitkar formed a seven-member committee headed by Public Health Commissioner Sanjay Katkar and directed it to submit its report within eight days. He said the committee’s findings would be made public

The burning question of child safety at hospitals

Survivors, rescuers, and hospital staff flag lapses in fire safety audits after 3 newborns were killed in a blaze that broke out at a government maternity hospital in Maharashtra’s Amravati district last month



The charred remains of medical equipment after a fire ripped through the neonatal intensive care unit of a government hospital in Amravati district of Maharashtra on August 24. EMMANUAL YOGINI

and responsibility fixed.

On August 26, Mr. Katkar and the committee visited the spot and questioned the nurses who were present in the NICU at the time of the incident. The CCTV footage was also handed over to the committee, which comprises officials from the Maharashtra State Electricity Board, AIIMS and the Directorate of Medical Education and Research. It has been tasked with examining ventilator and electrical faults, the fire-audit his-

tory and administrative lapses. The report was due on August 31 but has not yet been released.

Maharashtra Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis announced ₹5 lakh in compensation for each family that lost its newborn in the fire and directed that the treatment of injured infants be fully covered by the government.

Of the 36 newborn babies, 11 have been admitted to Dr. Panjabrao Deshmukh Memorial Medical College (PDMMC), 10 to

Hope Hospital, eight to Murkey Hospital and two to Parijat Hospital. Five were discharged with their mothers.

Survivors’ accounts

Radhika Yehkade, 19, was the last to deliver her twins before the fire. They were born around 2 a.m. on August 24 and kept in the NICU. “I had a difficult pregnancy. I was in the hospital the week before my delivery. I am unable to let go of the voices in my head. Nurses shouting, ‘Help,’

people screaming, ‘Fire, fire.’ I am unable to make peace with the fact that my babies’ lives would have lasted only for two hours,” says Radhika, whose twins were admitted to PDMMC.

Radhika’s mother, Phula Shanware, 55, also an eyewitness, adds, “The smoke was dense; the fire brigade reached in time but took almost an hour to take water pipes to the third floor.”

Talking about her daughter, Phula says, “She had a tough pregnancy; we are daily wage earners and have already spent ₹80,000. We have been far from our house in Achalpur for almost 10 days.”

Another woman, Arti Kharale, 27, narrated her story. “When I saw my daughter, she smelt of wet ash. My heart sank when I heard about the fire,” says Arti, who lives in Amravati city. She says this was the second such fire in the hospital. The last, as reported by the media, was in September 2022.

Yogesh Savarkar, 24, is waiting outside the maternity room at PDMMC, where his daughter and wife have been transferred. He narrates, “When I entered, I saw three children covered in black powder. One child had burns on his face. We rescued them first.”

Chief Minister Fadnavis has raised concerns over the hospital’s mandatory fire audit.

According to data from Maharashtra’s Public Health Department, of the

530 government hospitals across the State, 528 have completed fire audits. As many as 442 hospitals have fire safety systems fully installed, while only 372 hospitals hold a fire no-objection certificate (NOC).

In Amravati alone, 18 government hospitals were audited, of which 16 received the NOC.

On August 25, the Public Health Department announced a State-wide fire and electrical safety inspection of all government, private and charitable hospitals. Minister Abitkar had said, “If discrepancies are found in the audit, then they are to be rectified. Every hospital will appoint a nodal officer for fire safety, who will review fire audits, electrical safety, fire-fighting systems, emergency evacuation arrangements, staff training, and mock drills, and submit compliance information to senior levels.”

Initial warning

Records show that the Dufferin Hospital Authority had flagged concerns over the fire safety systems. A letter dated June 29 stated, “The hospital had obtained a fire NOC valid from June 22, 2025, to June 21, 2026. Before this validity period lapses, a registered licensed agency must conduct a fire safety audit, and Form B must be submitted to this office – so the fire NOC renewal proposal can then be forwarded to the Fire Department of Amravati Municipal

Corporation.”

A follow-up letter was also written to the Public Works Department on July 17, reminding it to arrange a fire safety audit.

The ventilators in both cases were supplied by Schiller Healthcare, which has been called for the investigation. An official said a committee will be set up to create SOPs for the procurement of medical equipment.

Courage under fire

Outside the NICU, the smell of smoke lingered. In the corridor, *kaksh-sevikas* (nursing attendants) were waiting for their turns to appear before the committee as part of the investigation. Among them was Surekha Dhanvijay, 45, one of the four attendants present in the NICU, who witnessed the fire and called for help. “The moment I heard the explosion, a huge flame burst out. With our bare hands, we tried to douse the fire near the cradle and take a baby out.”

“I have only one regret: that we couldn’t save those three children,” says Kirti Ghanvir, 45, another nursing attendant.

The *sevikas* say they do not want any appreciation as they consider this part of their jobs, but appeal to the government to increase their salaries. They say they currently get ₹8,000 a month and are hired on contract, so their salaries barely increase.

snehal.mutha@thehindu.co.in



Steady gaze

ISRO's EOS-05 satellite has uses in varied areas from security to weather

The successful launch of the Indian Space Research Organisation's (ISRO) EOS-05 satellite is India's first earth-imaging satellite built for a geosynchronous orbit, meaning that it is locked-in to the earth's rotation and can be tuned to continuously observe the same location. The rocket placed it in a transfer orbit early on Friday; onboard thrusters are expected to raise it to its final perch at some 36,000 kilometres above the earth's surface over the coming weeks. From there it can track fast-changing events such as floods, cyclones and forest fires, and monitor crops, forests, water bodies and land use. Unlike a conventional camera, its sensors examine how the earth's surface reflects different wavelengths of light, helping distinguish vegetation, water and other land cover. Because it is perched farther away than conventional low-orbit imaging satellites, its strength is not ultra-fine detail but the ability to return to the same broad areas very frequently. India has long had eyes in geostationary orbit, but they have been weather satellites, namely the INSAT-3D series. Its dedicated earth-imaging satellites have operated in low, polar or sun-synchronous orbits. Flying a few hundred kilometres up, they capture much finer detail, but move constantly around the planet, imaging a different strip of territory on successive passes and taking days to return.

EOS-05's timing could hardly be better. Given the devastation by the Bhote Koshi deluge in Nepal, which has claimed 1,344 lives, such satellites can play some role in understanding changes in landforms and how they may act as precursors to glacier-breaks and avalanches. Or, as winter approaches in north India, in establishing whether stubble fires over Punjab have genuinely declined or burning has simply shifted in time to slip past the polar satellites. ISRO has described the EOS-05 as a "strategic" satellite, a term that stretches from security to weather. All of this is premised on the data reaching a wide enough set of analysts who can turn the images into forecasts and actionable insight. There is cheer, too, that ISRO's first successful launch of 2026 – and another vote of confidence in the cryogenic stage that failed the agency in 2021 – comes after set-backs. But that does not soften the temperamental nature of launches. Two consecutive failures of the PSLV, the agency's workhorse since the 1990s, in May last year and again this January, both traced to the third stage, suggest that dependability is not infallibility. The usefulness of its payloads, and the cadence of its launches, should be ISRO's calling card, rather than any single launch as the hallmark of institutional credibility.

Bogged down

The U.S. should revive the MoU with Iran to cut its losses

Iran's attacks on American warships outside the Strait of Hormuz and U.S. retaliatory strikes on three Iranian oil tankers in the Gulf waters mark another phase of escalation in the six-month-long war between the two countries. After the collapse of the June 17 Islamabad Memorandum of Understanding (MoU), which sought to resolve the conflict through talks, both sides have carried out tit-for-tat attacks. Last month, U.S. President Donald Trump appeared to shift the focus of his Iran policy from military strikes to economic warfare, announcing new sanctions and tightening the U.S. Navy's blockade of Iran's ports. The U.S. also managed to get some oil tankers through the Strait of Hormuz through a southern route along the Omani coast. But Iran, which still maintains its chokehold over the waterway, continued to target vessels taking the southern route. Unable to find a way out, the U.S. returned to strikes, triggering Iranian attacks on American bases in Kuwait, Bahrain and Jordan. The latest escalation is significant because it is the first time in months that Iran has attacked U.S. military vessels, apparently seeking to break the blockade. By targeting Iranian tankers in retaliation, the U.S. has also crossed a red line. The Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps announced that it had struck six vessels in the Gulf – three tankers and three U.S.-linked ships – in retaliation for the American attacks on oil tankers, and vowed to expand their strikes against U.S. ships.

The central focus of the war today, which the U.S. and Israel launched on February 28 in the name of destroying Iran's nuclear programme and bringing about regime change in Tehran, is the Strait of Hormuz. That Tehran forced the U.S. to fight over a problem it created rather than pursue Washington's original objective is, in itself, a strategic victory for Iran. The frequent clashes and counter-clashes underscore two points. First, the U.S. does not have a clear theory of victory. Neither its military effort nor its economic warfare has forced Iran to change its position. The Strait remains unsafe, while the toll on the global economy is mounting. What the Trump administration appears to be doing is 'mowing the lawn', taken straight out of the Israeli play-book, with the aim of blunting Iran's attack capabilities. But each time, Iran retaliates, pursuing its own 'debasification' strategy, pushing U.S. military presence away from its immediate periphery. Second, Iran, despite its economic woes, has emerged more assertive. The more the U.S. seeks to trap Iran in an economic gridlock, the less risk-averse Tehran appears to be. As both sides seek escalation dominance, the war risks spiralling out of control. America is visibly under pressure. Mr. Trump must to accept the cold fact that he has lost this war and return to reviving the MoU before it is too late.

Serious allegations against the Acting Chief Justice of the Rajasthan High Court, Justice Sanjeev Prakash Sharma, have come to light following reports of letters written by Supreme Court of India judge Justice Sandeep Mehta to the Chief Justice of India (CJI), in which he has sought Justice Sharma's immediate transfer. Justice Mehta, who previously served as a judge of the Rajasthan High Court and is regarded for his uprightness, discipline, and integrity, wrote three such letters on August 2, 10, and 17. The contents of these letters are now partly in the public domain.

Letters that raise serious questions

The letters reportedly refer to complaints about the manner in which Justice Sharma has been functioning. They also highlight alleged instances of victimisation of judges, maladministration, improper "shifting of cases" to his Bench, and nepotism in appointments to the Permanent Lok Adalat. Justice Sharma has allegedly been intimidating some of his colleagues with the threat of retributive measures, including transfers, based on his claimed proximity to the CJI. It is reported that Justice Mehta's letters refer to specific instances of alleged favouritism towards a chosen few among the lawyers and the misuse of power in his capacity as the "master of the roster". Justice Mehta's last letter reportedly expresses concern over the CJI's alleged inaction, particularly as Justice Sharma is due to retire on September 26. So far, there has been no official denial of the reports concerning the contents of the letters. Justice Sharma, of course, has publicly denied the accusations as baseless.

A High Court functioning without a regular Chief Justice and functioning under an Acting Chief Justice for a considerably long period – in the instant case, for about 11 months – is not a good institutional gesture. The fact that Justice Sharma was earlier transferred to the Patna High Court in 2022, and that his request for repatriation to the Rajasthan High Court was rejected by the Collegium in 2023, which instead proposed his transfer to the Punjab and Haryana High Court, is also not a commendable antecedent. Justice Mehta, according to reports, is said to have wondered how such a judge came to be retransferred to the Rajasthan High Court in 2025 and subsequently allowed to function as the Acting Chief Justice, with wide-ranging administrative and judicial powers.

Of late, there have been two crucial developments. First, lawyers at the Rajasthan High Court staged a sit-in protest on the High Court premises, following which Justice Sharma had to opt out from hearing cases. Second, on August 31, the Supreme Court Collegium recommended the appointment of Justice Sanjay Agrawal as the new Chief Justice of the Rajasthan



Kaleeswaram Raj

Lawyer at the Supreme Court of India

Allegations against a High Court judge raise serious questions about judicial accountability in India

High Court. Accordingly Justice Agrawal is now appointed.

Allegations of corruption against sitting judges in India are neither uncommon nor unprecedented. Yet, certain unique features of the present reports are worth noting. A sitting judge of the Supreme Court reportedly alerted the CJI to the conduct of an Acting Chief Justice of a High Court, supported by verifiable material.

Yet, for several weeks, no cogent steps were reportedly initiated by the CJI in this regard. The CJI reportedly said that the allegations could not be treated as findings and that they "must be dealt with strictly through the established institutional mechanism". In view of Justice Sharma's impending retirement, early action by the CJI to Justice Mehta's letter could perhaps have averted some of the disturbing events that subsequently followed.

Transparency International, in its reports, has underlined the growing trust deficit in the Indian judiciary. According to its 2002 report, based on a household survey, the judiciary was identified as the second-most corrupt institution in certain South Asian countries, including India. The report is indeed shocking. Yet, the present situation in India is far more complex and multi-dimensional. There are many fine judges in India's judiciary whose integrity and public image should not be tarnished because of aberrations elsewhere, whether on or off the Bench.

Institutional responsibility, structural issues

The repeated episodes of judicial corruption in India reflect certain fundamental issues concerning the functioning of its higher judiciary.

First, the total lack of criteria, coupled with the unavoidable collaboration between the Collegium and the Executive at the Centre under the present system, makes judicial appointments highly partisan, opaque, and often arbitrary. This mechanism and its processes are incapable of identifying the cleanest and most meritorious candidates. The issue of corruption in the judiciary, like many other institutional concerns, is inseparable from the existing method of selecting candidates for judicial office. A system of inviting applications, as is prevalent in Canada, or an independent body for judicial selection, as in the United Kingdom, remains unthinkable in India.

Second, the lack of an effective mechanism to deal with corruption in the higher judiciary in India has had the effect of perpetuating the menace. The Judges (Inquiry) Act, 1968, is inadequate to tackle the issue and has, for all practical purposes, become defunct. The Supreme Court, in *K. Veeraswami vs Union of India* (1991), held that, for registering a First Information Report against a judge of the higher judiciary, the permission of the CJI is a necessary

precondition. As lawyer Prashant Bhushan rightly observed, "the police does not dare approach the Chief Justice for permission to investigate, unless they already have clinching evidence, which they cannot get, unless they investigate" ("Judicial Accountability or Illusion?", *Economic and Political Weekly*, November 25, 2006). Although the United Progressive Alliance government facilitated the passage of the Judicial Standards and Accountability Bill in the Lok Sabha in 2012, the Bill lapsed with the dissolution of the 15th Lok Sabha in 2014. The subsequent legislative effort to revive the Bill, with some changes, also remained a non-starter. The impeachment of erring judges, as suggested by Articles 124(4) and 217(1)(b) of the Constitution, has proved to be a failure. Likewise, the in-house mechanism adopted by the Supreme Court in 1999 has not proved to be fault-free or even effective.

Earlier crises, different responses

But these considerations could not have been reasons for the CJI not to act promptly upon the concerns allegedly expressed by Justice Mehta. On the contrary, the lack of a permanent systemic solution to the issues raised should have been an additional reason for the CJI to take remedial measures expeditiously and diligently, and to do whatever was possible within his authority. The situation called for judicial statesmanship. In 1990, when an inquiry was underway against Justice V. Ramaswami for alleged misconduct, he was advised by then CJI Sabyasachi Mukharji, to take leave and keep away from judicial work.

Thereafter, when the impeachment motion against Justice Ramaswami failed in Parliament due to the Congress party's strategic abstention, the judge attempted to resume judicial work, with about nine months of his tenure remaining.

However, then CJI Venkatachaliah refused to allocate any cases to him for hearing, notes Justice K. Chandru in his book, *Who Will Judge the Judges?* (2026). Even last year, when partly burnt currency notes were reportedly found in the outhouse of Justice Yashwant Varma at his Delhi residence, then CJI Sanjiv Khanna, quickly transferred him to the Allahabad High Court, where he was not allocated any judicial work, practically. In the reported decision in *XXX vs Union of India* (2025), the Supreme Court emphasised the responsibility of the CJI in matters relating to judicial integrity and allegations of corrupt practices.

Justice Sharma allegedly claimed that the CJI is proximate to him. This was a factor that led to undesirable and avoidable speculations. Given the nature of the allegations and their immediate verifiability, it was imperative that the CJI acted promptly and convincingly, so that further damage to the system and the institution could have been reduced, if not prevented altogether.

Harnessing BRICS 'POWER' to empower the world

The 18th BRICS Summit is about to be held in New Delhi on September 12-13, 2026. China extends full support to India for its BRICS presidency, stands ready to work with all BRICS members and partners to jointly draw a blueprint for the high-quality development of a greater BRICS, and leverage BRICS POWER to empower the world. I would like to share my personal views on the greater BRICS cooperation, with the help of the five letters of the word Power.

The first is P for Principle. The world is now undergoing accelerated transformation unseen in a century, and witnessing a trend toward deepening multipolarity, economic globalisation, and the collective rise of the Global South. In the meantime, hegemonism and power politics are becoming increasingly rampant. Lingering geopolitical conflicts trigger a succession of crises and challenges.

As an important force for world peace and development, BRICS must resolutely uphold the purposes and principles of the United Nations Charter, and safeguard the basic norms of international relations, including sovereign equality, non-interference in internal affairs and peaceful settlement of disputes, and prevent the world from sliding back into the law of the jungle where the strong prey on the weak.

Upholding international principles

Chinese President Xi Jinping put forward the vision of building a community with a shared future for humanity and four global initiatives, including the Global Security Initiative and the Global Governance Initiative, which provided China's solutions on addressing common human challenges and building a better world together.

The second is O for Openness. The world economy is currently facing a sluggish recovery, coupled with the spread of protectionism. Certain countries have undermined the international economic and trade order by erecting tariff barriers, seeking decoupling and disrupting supply chains.

It should be recognised that economic globalisation is an inevitable trend of history. BRICS should uphold the multilateral trading system with the World Trade Organization (WTO)



Xu Feihong

The Chinese Ambassador to India

The five commitments for strengthening BRICS cooperation and empowering the Global South to build a more peaceful, open, and prosperous world

at its core, safeguard the basic principles of the WTO such as the most-favoured-nation treatment, and resist all forms of protectionism. We should join hands to deepen cooperation in energy and mineral resources, infrastructure, and industrial and supply chains to maintain an open global economic landscape.

China stays committed to building an open global economy, so as to share opportunities in openness, and achieve common development.

The third is W for Win-Win. BRICS should adhere to the Spirit of Openness, Inclusiveness and Win-Win cooperation. We should continue putting development at the centre of the BRICS agenda, accelerate the implementation of the UN Sustainable Development Goals, strengthen dialogue and build consensus on launching the formulation of the post-2030 global development agenda, and ensure that Global South countries participate in international cooperation as equals and share the fruits of development.

Economic and financial cooperation

We should pursue mutual benefit and win-win results to further consolidate economic cooperation. It is necessary to strengthen greater BRICS coordination on macroeconomic policies and adopt more trade and investment facilitation measures. We should push forward local currency and cross-border payment cooperation and improve the financial safety net, so as to enhance the ability to ward off external risks. In the face of global energy and food security challenges, we should build a more resilient and sustainable agriculture and food system.

The fourth is E for Engine. BRICS countries account for nearly half of the world's population, around 30% of global economic output, and one-fifth of global trade. We are also home to major natural resources, key manufacturers and vast markets. According to international agencies such as the International Monetary Fund, greater BRICS growth will be nearly three times faster than the G-7 by 2028, further highlighting its role as an engine of world economic growth.

We should leverage our respective advantages, deepen practical cooperation in fields such as business, finance, science and technology,

forging more cooperation in the digital economy, smart manufacturing, and new industrialisation. We should actively promote the integration of artificial intelligence (AI) with sectors including science and technology, health, agriculture and education, thereby injecting fresh impetus into world economic growth. China has established the China-BRICS AI Development and Cooperation Center and the China-BRICS New Quality Productive Forces Research Center, and welcomes active participation of all parties.

The fifth is R for Responsibility. BRICS countries are the main force in safeguarding fairness and justice and the backbone of promoting unity and cooperation. We must shoulder the responsibility of maintaining world peace and development. Over this year and the next, India and China will take on the BRICS rotating presidency in succession. Maintaining sound coordination between our two countries is conducive to the steady and sustained progress of greater BRICS' cooperation, and will better safeguard the common interests of developing countries.

China-India ties

Since the beginning of this year, under the strategic guidance of the two leaders, President Xi Jinping and Prime Minister Narendra Modi, China-India relations have maintained a momentum of improvement and development. The two sides strengthened dialogues at all levels and promoted exchanges and cooperation in various fields to achieve positive results. Five direct flight routes between the Chinese mainland and India have been resumed. After a six-year suspension, border trade has been reopened.

China looks forward to working with India to translate the important consensus reached by the two leaders into concrete actions, being good-neighbourly friends and partners that help each other, and pushing China-India relations to move forward in a sustained, healthy, and stable manner. May the 18th BRICS Summit in New Delhi be a great success. We welcome you all to China next year to continue empowering the world with BRICS POWER.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Dangers on highways

A series of accidents on national highways has drawn attention to the serious problem of illegal parking along highways. Even a seemingly minor instance can lead to devastating accidents. The

recent accidents seem to have drawn the government's attention to the issue and highlighted the urgent need to take effective measures to reduce the number of accidents and casualties. Strict action against illegal

parking, along with improved road safety measures, can play a significant role in preventing such tragic incidents (Front page, September 6).
Salman,
Kozhikode, Kerala

Spurious rabies vaccines

The seizure of spurious rabies vaccines and the failure of such vaccines at a private laboratory recently expose a critical breach in medical safety. Rabies has a near-100% case fatality rate once clinical symptoms

manifest, making timely, potent post-exposure prophylaxis the only defence against an otherwise almost invariably fatal disease. A fake vaccine creates a lethal illusion of security. Regulatory authorities must enforce

strict track-and-trace systems and batch verification across the supply chain.

Dr. Vijaykumar H.K.,
Raichur, Karnataka

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address.

The political cost of UCT schemes

Since 2020, Unconditional Cash Transfer (UCT) schemes have become an important electoral strategy in India, particularly to attract women voters. Some examples of such schemes include the Kalaigarn Magalir Urimai Thittam in Tamil Nadu, the Lakshmir Bhandar in West Bengal, and Gruha Lakshmi Yojana in Karnataka. Yet, despite increasing the amount of cash before the 2026 elections, some governments which implemented these schemes were defeated. One possible explanation for the loss could be the political cost associated with UCTs.

UCT schemes are well-intentioned as they provide financial support to women. They partially advance SDG (Sustainable Development Goal) 5.4, which calls for a recognition of women's unpaid domestic and care work. According to the Ministry of Finance's latest Economic Survey, States are expected to spend about \$18 billion on UCTs in 2025-26, much of it targeted towards women.

Critics, however, argue that these schemes function as electoral "freebies." Their financing often requires expenditure switching or larger fiscal deficits, and reduces resources available for productive investments, including employment generation and self-employment programmes. Moreover, once households become dependent on UCTs, withdrawing them is difficult as political parties encourage competitive welfarism.

Targeting challenges
A fundamental challenge in targeted UCT programmes is beneficiary identification. Since governments cannot



K. R. Shanmugam

Former Director, Madras School of Economics and Economic Consultant to GoTN



Sankarganesh Karuppiah

Indian Revenue Services Officer

Linking benefits to socially desirable outcomes produces broader developmental gains

directly observe incomes for most workers in the informal sector, they rely on proxy indicators such as land ownership, electricity consumption, or household assets. This inevitably produces both inclusion errors (benefits reaching ineligible households) and exclusion errors (eligible households being left out). These targeting errors, whether real or perceived, can impose significant political costs.

The Kalaigarn Magalir Urimai Thittam scheme illustrates this challenge. Although the ruling party at the time promised ₹1,000 per month to all women-headed households before the 2021 election, fiscal constraints led the government to restrict eligibility based on income, land ownership, and other criteria when the scheme was launched in September 2023. Initially, about 1.13 crore women were covered. Following widespread complaints from women who believed they met the eligibility criteria, another 16.94 lakh beneficiaries were added in December 2025. The scheme cost ₹13,807 crore in 2025-26.

Despite the expansion, dissatisfaction persisted. Many women who considered themselves unfairly excluded reportedly became even more aggrieved when eligible beneficiaries received an advance payment of three months' entitlement along with a special summer relief payment. Although the precise electoral impact cannot be measured, even modest shifts in voter preferences can influence outcomes in closely contested constituencies.

These experiences highlight an important

feature of targeted welfare programmes. Political costs arise not only from actual errors but also from perceived ones. Individuals who fail to satisfy official eligibility criteria may nevertheless believe that they have been treated unfairly. Likewise, households that legally qualify may be perceived as undeserving because they appear relatively affluent. Such perceived targeting errors can be as politically consequential as actual administrative mistakes.

This reveals an inherent tension between economics and politics. Economics favours targeted programmes so that scarce public resources reach those most in need. Politics, however, rewards broader inclusion because voters evaluate governments not only by the benefits they receive but also by those they believe were unfairly denied. Consequently, targeted UCT programmes carry an unavoidable political cost.

Conditional cash transfers and other incentive-based welfare programmes offer a more sustainable alternative. Linking benefits to socially desirable outcomes produces broader developmental gains. Tamil Nadu's Midday Meal Scheme illustrates this principle. Since participation depends on school enrolment, self-selection reduces grievances.

The broader lesson is that welfare programmes tied to education or other desirable behaviours can achieve developmental objectives with lower political costs. In contrast, UCTs remain inherently vulnerable to inclusion, exclusion, and perceived targeting errors.

India's unemployment data dilemma

The government has finally found a way to measure the statistical elephant of unemployment; however, it may be incomplete – much like the blind men who touched different parts of a pachyderm and mistook it for the whole truth.

The challenge in measuring the unemployment rate using the Current Weekly Status (CWS) approach – where a person's activity status is determined based on the preceding seven days – is to assess not only whether people are employed, but also the nature of their jobs, the frequency and regularity of their payments, and the overall quality of employment. In an economy where a vast majority of the population are involved in informal work, employment cannot be analysed through a headline rate of high frequency indicator, if it can be called so.

India's decision to transform the quarterly/yearly unemployment data into a monthly indicator is economically desirable, even if its credibility is questionable given the nature of its database, which seldom takes into account circular migration.

Efforts have been made to strengthen India's database comprising EPFO (Employees' Provident Fund Organisation) and ESIC (Employees' State Insurance Corporation) payroll data, GST-based enterprise information, income tax records, corporate payroll data, gig economy employment data, and rural wage indicators but at present, even these sources remain fragmented. Unlike a



Santosh V. Perumal

mature labour market – comprising payroll surveys, unemployment insurance records, formal contracts, and extensive administrative databases – India's large informal employment market is difficult to track.

Most advanced nations count unemployment using a Labour Force Survey based on the definition of the International Labour Organization (ILO). The U.S., Japan, EU and the U.K. have decades of household survey data with detailed information on full-time versus part-time jobs, hourly wages, job duration, labour mobility, and unemployment spells.

A leading indicator

The latest Periodic Labour Force Survey (PLFS) says that India's unemployment rate for those aged 15 years and above marked a four-month low of 5.1% in July. The review period coincided with the peak of kharif season, when demand for agricultural labour rose for land preparation, transplanting, and allied activities. Since construction, agriculture, small trade, logistics, and local services see seasonal fluctuations, it is likely that July's decline reflects increased hiring in these segments rather than a broad-based expansion in formal sector jobs.

Monthly unemployment should at the best be a leading indicator, not a comprehensive measure of labour market health.

India has a labour market where various reports suggest that 90% of the population are involved in the informal sector; agricultural employment remains seasonal, with wage payments negotiated informally and where

underemployment/disguised employment is widespread. Indicating limited granularity, data is rather sketchy on wage growth, hours worked, job quality, occupational shifts, and sector-wise employment trends. Therefore, monthly unemployment data reflects seasonal movements rather than structural improvement. A fall in unemployment may indicate distress-driven entry into low-productivity jobs rather than genuine employment creation.

The overall decline in unemployment was owing to rural areas, where unemployment declined to 4.5% from 5%; but it should not be read as a major improvement in the job market. Independent labour studies estimate that there are between 30 to 35 million seasonal labourers moving across India annually, forming the invisible backbone of urban construction and infrastructure.

The July data saw an increase in the labour force participation rate, a positive supply-side signal, but stronger investment and job creation prefix sustainable employment recovery. The challenge is to convert this participation into stable, high-productivity jobs.

The revamped PLFS is a significant improvement over earlier low-frequency labour statistics but its success ultimately depends on whether it gauges the reality of the job market – not merely measuring it more frequently. A credible labour market barometer is the need of the hour to capture the livelihoods of millions of workers.

santosh.v@thehindu.co.in

18 centuries: tracing Smriti Mandhana's journey to the top

With her record-breaking century at the Asia Cup, Smriti Mandhana surpassed Mithali Raj to become the highest run scorer in women's international cricket

DATA POINT

Devvyanshi Bihani

When Smriti Mandhana scored her 18th international century against Hong Kong at the Women's T20 Asia Cup in Dubai on September 3 – in just 57 balls – she set a new record for scoring the highest number of centuries in women's international cricket across all formats. That was not the only record she broke in that match.

By the time she was run out for 124, she had overtaken her former captain Mithali Raj to become the highest run-scorer in women's international cricket. She had taken her career tally to 10,880 runs, 12 more than Mithali's record of 10,868. Her score was also the highest in the history of the Women's T20 Asia Cup, surpassing Chamari Athapaththu's 119 not out from 2024.

Her seven sixes took her career tally to 95, making her the leading six-hitter for India in women's T20Is and the fourth-highest in the world. Smriti also became the first Indian woman to score more than one century in the T20 format, and while doing so, she equalled Mithali's record of 93 fifty-plus scores in international cricket

Mandhana's century-making was a slow burn before it became a sprint. Her international career began with a T20 match against Bangladesh in April 2013, three months before she turned 17. She waited for three years to taste her first century, in her 32nd international innings in 2016 against Australia. But it took 115 more innings and five years to reach her fifth, and another 92 innings to get to 10. Then, the sprint started. Ten of her 18 centuries came within the last two years, and at a notably higher strike rate (**Chart 1**).

Winning streak

That acceleration becomes even more striking when compared

with the other top five century-makers. Australia's Meg Lanning reached 10 hundreds in 123 innings, just about half the number of 239 innings that Smriti took to score hers. All the other four crossed the milestone of 10 before their 200th innings. In contrast, Smriti's performance has soared after she crossed her 200th (**Chart 2**). Of Smriti's 18 centuries, 14 came from ODIs, two in Tests and two in T20Is.

In ODIs, she has scored 5,411 runs with an average of 47.88. In 16 Test innings, she scored 788 with an average of 52.53 and in 167 T20I innings, she scored 4,681 runs with an average of 30.65. Across all three formats, she has 10,880 runs, 75 fifties and an average of 38.86, showing that her record is built on consistency as much as several spectacular peaks.

Moreover, the pace at which she has accumulated her runs really sets her apart.

While she had already become the fastest woman to reach 10,000 runs in just 281 innings, she has now become the highest run scorer in 303 international innings – fewer than the other four players with more than 10,000 runs, all of whom, except Stafanie Taylor, are now retired from international cricket (**Chart 3**).

This pace is reflected in how Smriti clearly stands out with her overall strike rate of 99.57. It is nearly 10 points higher than Suzie, the next fastest among the five. Batting average is the only indicator where she lags among the five, but that too only against her compatriot and inspiration Mithali (**Chart 4**). She is in the same league as the other three.

A few years back, she had said that her mother taught her to persevere – “to go on till reaching the top”. Smriti had also said that she wanted to be the best batter in the world. At just 30, she may have already realised that ambition. But, as she said in the press conference after her records-breaking Hong Kong match, “it is just the start”.

Gearing up for higher peaks

The data for the charts were sourced from Statsguru, the searchable cricket statistics database available at cricinfo.com. All the figures are as of September 4, 2026, when the data was collected

CHART 1: Ten of Smriti's 18 centuries came in the last two years. Her centuries have also been accompanied by a higher strike rate

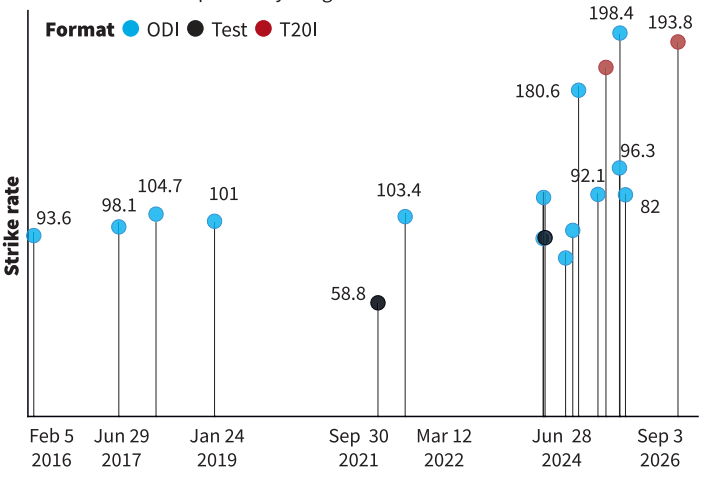


CHART 2: Most of the centuries of the other top scorers came before their 200th innings. Smriti became prolific after crossing her 200th

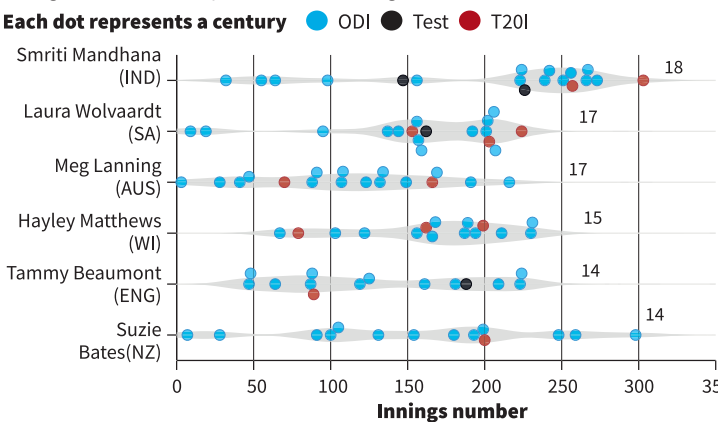


CHART 4: Smriti took fewer innings to become the top scorer with a higher strike rate while Mithali holds the highest average

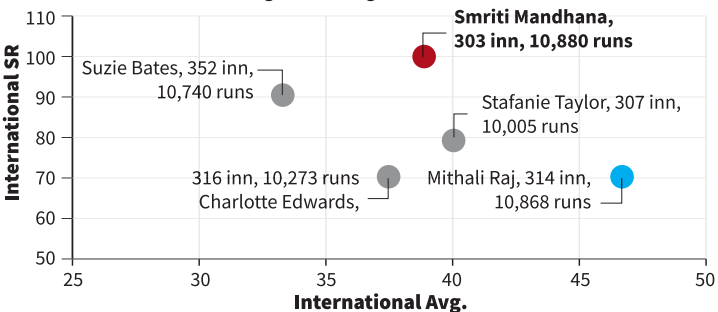
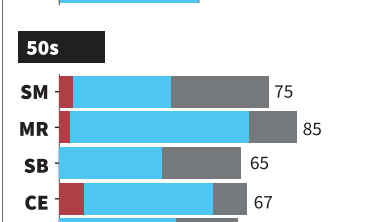
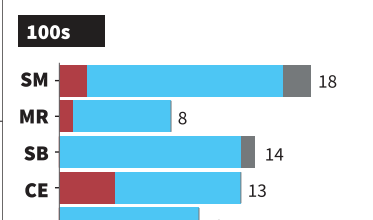
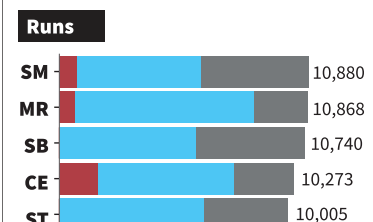
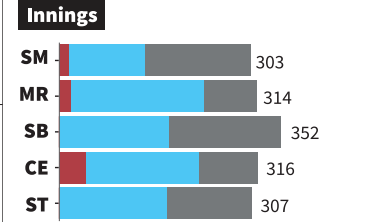


CHART 3: Smriti's innings, runs, centuries, and fifties, in comparison with the other four players who have scored over 10,000 runs in women's international cricket

Mithali Raj - **MR** (IND), Smriti Mandhana - **SM** (IND), Suzie Bates - **SB** (NZ), Charlotte Edwards - **CE** (ENG), Stafanie Taylor - **ST** (WI)

● Test ● ODI ● T20I



FROM THE ARCHIVES

The Hindu

FIFTY YEARS AGO SEPTEMBER 7, 1976

Snake boats to be standardised

Kottayam, September 6: A scheme has been prepared by a Government-sponsored Committee to standardise the snake boat which is the main attraction in the boat races in Kerala.

This Government Committee conducts the Nehru Trophy boat race. The existing boat races are losing their charm because the competing snake boats are of different lengths, and the capacity of rowers differ.

Many of the snake boats in Central Travancore like Pacha, Payipad and Kodupunna can carry between 70 and 80 rowers, while the snake boats like Karichal, Kallooparamban and Jawahar Thayankari can take in over 100 persons. Because of this vast disparity in manpower, the snake boats like Karichal and Kallooparamban alone are now winning the trophies in most of the races. In the light of this, a scheme has been prepared by the Nehru Trophy Boat Race Committee to standardise the snake boats with equal length and strength of rowers.

The Committee is also considering the grant of loans to help this standardisation. According to a tentative scheme, a loan of Rs. 10,000 will be given to each boat.

Four major boat races will be held in various parts of Central Travancore this weekend. The Sree Narayana boat race will be held on September 8, while the Vembanad boat race will be conducted on September 9.

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO SEPTEMBER 7, 1926

Railway extension in the Punjab

Lahore, September 6: In accordance with the new policy of railway extension in the Punjab, a reference to which was made by the Governor while inaugurating the Kangra Valley Railway in May last, two other lines Shahdara Narawal and Sirhind Rupar Railways have been sanctioned which are the type of those cross connections to which the Governor referred as being essential for the comfort and convenience of passenger traffic. The first is a line between Lyallpur and Jaranwala, which will pass through the rich tract irrigated by the Lower Chenab Canal. The other will link up Rohtak, Gohana and Panipat forming a direct connection between the Delhi-Ambala line of the North-Western Railway.

Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Goal speed of Indian Railways’ hydrogen train

110 in kmph. The Indian Railways is working to operate the country's first hydrogen-powered train at speeds of up to 110 kmph after completing trials at 120 kmph, Railway Board Chairman and CEO Satish Kumar said. He said consultations were under way with all stakeholders to decide the rail sections on which the new hydrogen train could be operated. PTI

Number of people dead in Israel strikes in Lebanon

4 Lebanon said four people were killed on Sunday in strikes that Israel said it carried out after Hezbollah had launched drones at its soldiers in south Lebanon, the latest escalation amid a fragile truce. Lebanon's Health Ministry reported two people killed in south Lebanon's Nabatieh al-Fawqa and two women killed in nearby Arab Salim. It said 20 other people were wounded. AFP

Number of people affected by floods in Bihar

19.57 in lakh. Over 19 lakh people across 11 districts of Bihar have been affected by floods. Due to the rise in water levels of various rivers in the State, people in 330 gram panchayats across 11 districts — Patna, Bhojpur, Saran, Vaishali, Bhagalpur, Begusarai, Buxar, Samastipur, Munger, Katihar and Araria — have been affected, the officials said. PTI

Flights affected by Indonesia volcanic eruption

209 Indonesia halted operations at its main international airport outside Jakarta on Sunday after ash spewed from the Anak Krakatoa volcano more than 150 kilometres away, impacting thousands of passengers. Mount Anak Krakatoa erupted on Saturday, producing a fountain of lava and booming sounds that could be heard up to 700 kms. AFP

Percentage of voters deleted in Sikkim in SIR exercise

11 in per cent. A total of 52,551 electors were deleted from Sikkim's electoral roll during the Special Intensive Revision (SIR), reducing the number of voters by around 11.16%, a statement said. The final roll has 4,18,467 eligible voters, compared with 4,71,018 in the pre-SIR voters' list, the Chief Electoral Officer's office said in a statement. PTI

COMPILED BY THE HINDU DATA TEAM

Follow us facebook.com/thehindu X.com/the_hindu instagram.com/the_hindu

Does inflation targeting work in India?

India's Phillips curve is found to be flat, while households' inflation expectations remain consistently higher than the RBI's projections; this suggests that inflation targeting can lower output and employment without a commensurate reduction in inflation

ECONOMIC NOTES

Rohit Azad
Indranil Chowdhury

India has just completed a decade of inflation targeting (IT) as a formal policy framework of the Reserve Bank of India (RBI). Under this framework, the RBI is supposed to contain inflation at 4% within a band of (+/-) 2 percentage points. In this piece, we explain the theory behind inflation targeting and test it against the Indian experience.

Managing demands

The RBI seeks to control inflation through two channels: controlling demand and influencing the public's inflationary expectations. The RBI flexes its policy rate of interest (called the repo rate), which is increased when inflation kicks in. This pushes commercial banks' lending rates up.

Households become wary of taking home or consumer loans, while businesses postpone decisions to build factories. Demand comes down and, as a result, so does inflation.

The second route works through anchoring the inflationary expectations of the public at large. The assumption is that high expectations about inflation tomorrow influence inflation today because capitalists build these expectations into their current pricing decisions and workers into their wage decisions. Inflation is a self-fulfilling prophecy. So, if the RBI can somehow tether these expectations to its projected path of inflation, it can contain this prophecy. Both these routes work through a relationship called the New Keynesian Phillips curve (NKPC).

This curve describes a relationship between the level of GDP and inflation in an economy. It is proposed that a rise in output leads to an increase in inflation. Prices are a markup over costs. For simplicity, let us assume wages are the only costs in an economy. Workers demand wages; capitalists add a profit margin to determine prices. If wages rise, prices follow suit. But why should wages rise with output?

The wage-price negotiation process provides the key to understanding the NKPC. Consider a worker who would like to buy 5 kg of rice during a month for her family. Since she will not receive a sack of rice as her wage, she will have to settle for a money wage with which she can buy that amount of rice.

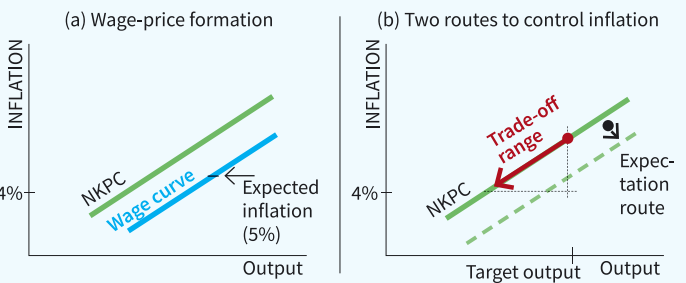
The time difference between fluctuations in money wages and the purchase of rice makes expectations a key factor in the process. For example, if she expects the price of 1 kg of rice at the time of purchase to be ₹100, she would negotiate for ₹500 as wages to buy those 5 kg. But if she expects the price to be ₹200, she would ask for ₹1,000. Wage costs would go up (for the same bundle of wage goods), as would prices.

A rise in output and employment, this framework argues, makes workers stronger and enables them to demand more rice — say from 5 kg to 6 kg — for the same number of hours of work. Thus, the wage demand curve rises with output (see panel (a) of **Graph 1**). Since prices are nothing but a markup over costs, the price curve (NKPC) has the same upward-sloping shape. On top of that, if the price expectations for rice were to change from ₹100 to ₹200, the wage demand curve, and the corresponding NKPC, would shift up for every level of

Off the mark

Ten years into inflation targeting, the Indian experience raises questions about its underlying assumptions

Graph 1: The New Keynesian Phillips Curve (NKPC)



Graph 2: A flat curve means lower output without lower inflation

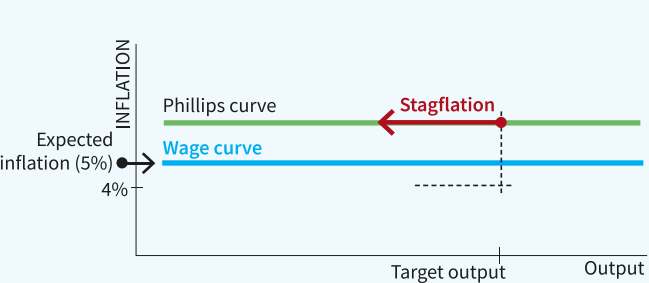


Chart 1: Testing the Phillips curve in India

April 2012 to March 2026

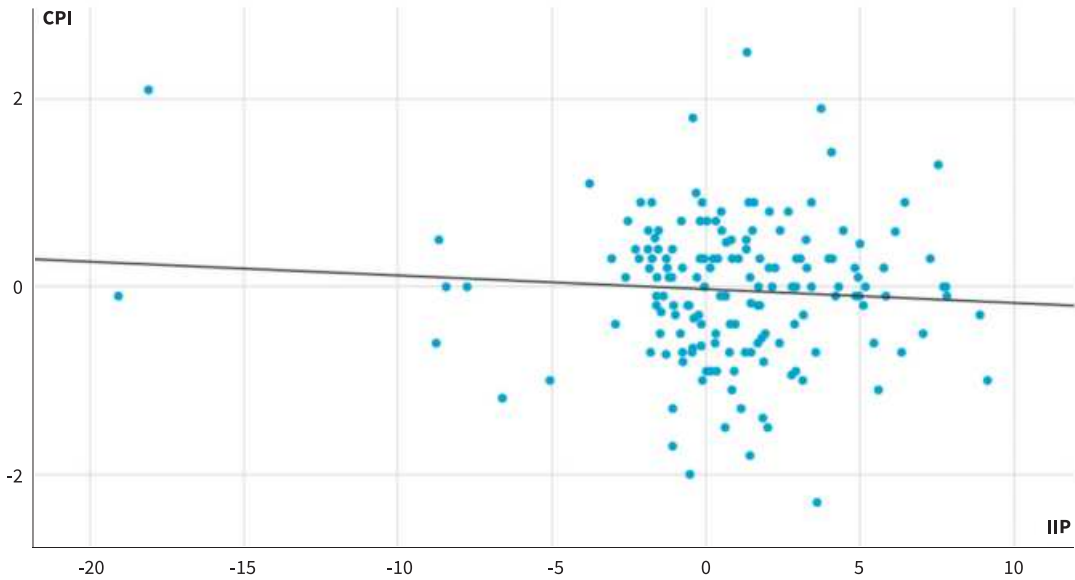


Chart: Azad & Chowdhury. Source: Database on Indian Economy, RBI

Chart 2(a): Household inflation expectations versus RBI projections

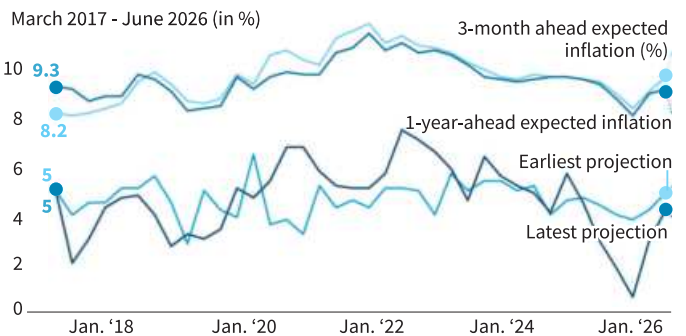


Chart: Azad & Chowdhury. Source: Households' Inflation Expectations Survey and Monetary Policy Statements, Various Years, RBI

Chart 2b: Household expected inflation and actual CPI inflation



Chart: Azad & Chowdhury. Source: Database on Indian Economy, RBI

output/ employment. In other words, the position of the NKPC is determined by expectations, and its slope by the bargaining power of workers and capitalists.

If the economy were to behave in this manner, there are two obvious ways to bring inflation under control (see panel (b) of Graph 1). Slide the economy down along the NKPC curve (the trade-off range marked in the graph where both inflation and output fall) or manoeuvre workers' expectations to a lower level across the board, so that the wage demand curve, hence the NKPC, shifts down, resulting in a fall in inflation with no impact on output. Expectation management is a less painful way of managing inflation. This is inflation targeting in a nutshell.

All of this works well in theory. But what if the real picture of the Indian economy is depicted in **Graph 2**? What if the NKPC is flat and there is no trade-off between output and inflation? Additionally, what if people's expectations do not match the RBI's projections of lower inflation in the future — that is, the flat NKPC stays put instead of shifting down? Then, a policy of inflation targeting, which brings output down without lowering inflation at all, leads to a combination of lower output and flat

stagflation (a left-pointed arrow in Graph 2).

Is the Indian Phillips curve upward sloping?

Our academic work published in the Economic and Political Weekly provides a more rigorous test of the Phillips curve, finding it to be flat under multiple configurations and methodologies. For the present purposes, a 'first cut' of that story is presented here. **Chart 1** uses monthly data on industrial output, as measured by the Index of Industrial Production (IIP), and CPI inflation between April 2012 and March 2026. The best-fit trend line in Chart 1 shows India's NKPC is, at best, flat.

But why is there such a gap between reality and mainstream economic theory? Because the basic premise of a rising wage demand curve, and consequently NKPC, as shown in Graph 1, is incorrect. For economies such as ours, an overwhelming majority of workers (around 92%) do not have any bargaining power, let alone fixing wages. They are simply price takers. Wages do not rise with output/employment.

Projections and expectations

Even if the Phillips curve is flat, IT

enthusiasts would argue that shifting it down would still do the job. But for this to happen, people's expectations should, by and large, match the RBI's projections. What does the Indian data tell us? The RBI surveys Indian households about their inflation expectations a quarter and one year ahead. These expectations are plotted over this period against the RBI's own projections. **Chart 2(a)** shows that expectations are consistently higher than the projections, that too, on average, by a margin of four percentage points. Even when expectations are plotted against actual inflation, the gap is similar (see **Chart 2(b)**). So, the expectations story is way off what is claimed to defend IT.

John Maynard Keynes would have asked the RBI: 'When facts change, I change my mind. What do you do sir?' Unfortunately, the RBI does the opposite as it tries to force-fit a macroeconomic model to a world where the underlying assumptions of the model do not hold. In the process, it inflicts pain on the common people of this country by forcing them out of employment without any commensurate gain in controlling inflation.

(The authors are a part of the DevMac (Development Macroeconomics) network, which seeks pluralism in Economics)

THE GIST

Inflation targeting works through higher interest rates to curb demand and through managing people's expectations of future inflation

The theory assumes that higher output and employment strengthen workers' bargaining power, pushing up wages and prices. However, this assumption does not hold well in India, where most workers have little bargaining power

The inflation-targeting framework relies on macroeconomic assumptions that may not reflect the realities of the Indian economy, potentially imposing high costs on employment and ordinary households

CACHE



Music lovers worldwide are noticing signs of AI tracks in both online and offline spaces, even as they call for greater transparency. GETTY IMAGES

Why Australia’s music industry banned AI music in chart listing

Australia’s ARIA has barred wholly AI-generated songs from its charts while allowing music made substantially by humans with AI assistance; the move has intensified calls for transparent AI labelling and greater accountability from streaming platforms

Sahana Venugopal

The story so far:
Australia’s music industry body – the Australian Recording Industry Association (ARIA) – on August 25 banned songs wholly made using AI, noting such tracks will be ineligible for listing on its charts. The announcement comes after the viral fame of an AI remix of Madonna’s 1989 song ‘Like a Prayer,’ made by Australian music producer and disc jockey Josh Fawaz earlier this year. The AI song enjoyed multiple weeks on the country’s top 20 chart and ranked second on ARIA’s top 20 Australian singles chart, per AP. It also scored over 23 million views on YouTube.

The use of AI to compose the song was not clearly disclosed initially, angering listeners and musicians who want synthetic music to be transparently labelled.

Which songs are banned under the new rules?
The industry body ARIA’s rules do not ban outright the use of AI in music. Neither does it have a zero-tolerance policy for AI in art. Instead, the updated code notes that a recording developed with the help of Gen AI is eligible for listing when it is “substantially human made” and “raises no stream or chart manipulation concerns.” This still leaves a lot of room for artists to create music with Generative AI tools.

In fact, ARIA CEO Annabelle Herd

To truly exclude AI-generated music from human creations, even casual listeners need a reliable way to differentiate between the two; for this, transparent labelling standards are required across platforms

insisted that the chart listings should evolve to “keep room for” artists already using AI tools in their work.
“The ARIA Charts will always remain a transparent measurement of the music Australia consumes, but a chart that rewards unlicensed AI output would undercut the very basis of the recorded music we exist to represent,” she said.

What penalties will users and distributors face?
ARIA has stated that it may reject ineligible recordings, apart from excluding them and removing them from charts whenever needed, adjusting chart positions, withdrawing accreditations, or rescinding its awards.
But when considering the global music industry as a whole, there is not much punitive action that original music artists and producers can take against users making AI-generated versions of their songs. The optics of a world-famous singer suing a small creator over an AI remix do not favour the true creators.
Instead, musical artistes and the companies representing them have been taking AI music generation platforms such



as Suno and Udio to court, accusing them of using copyrighted works without permission.
In late August, music publishers including Sony Music Publishing and Warner Chappell sued Anthropic, as well as its co-founders Dario Amodei and Benjamin Mann, alleging digital piracy and the data harvesting of copyrighted works.
Anthropic disagreed with the claims and intends to defend itself in court, reported *TechCrunch*.
Scraping copyrighted content to build AI is still a grey area. However, the 2025 ruling against Anthropic in the authors’ lawsuit that ended in a landmark \$1.5 billion settlement made one thing clear: that U.S. courts may take a more serious view of AI companies pirating copyrighted content for AI development.

Will music platforms be held accountable for AI?
To truly exclude AI-generated music from human creations, even casual listeners need a reliable way to differentiate between the two at first glance. For this, transparent labelling standards are

required across streaming platforms such as Spotify and Apple Music.
Later this month, Spotify users can expect to see “AI Persona” labels that identify artists who were entirely created with AI. In addition to this, Spotify will not include AI Personas in listeners’ editorial or algorithmic recommendations.
The labels will depend on both self-disclosure as well as the platform’s own checking process. Users will also be able to learn if the artist self-disclosed their AI status, or if Spotify had to apply the label.
While this label applies to AI artists, the platform has features such as AI Credits and SongDNA in order to understand if specific tracks were created with AI.
But more users are asking for ways to filter AI-generated or AI-assisted music entirely. A spike in unlabelled AI song tracks on platforms such as Instagram makes it difficult for creators to curate background music for their videos and photos. For example, art-based businesses marketing handmade goods to buyers can face flak over accidentally using AI music in their Reels. Taking down and re-uploading the Reel would cost them views.
Challenges exist offline as well. Music lovers and connoisseurs have complained that AI soundtracks are seeping into more public spaces, as commercial properties such as stores and cafés err on the side of caution by choosing generic AI music over popular licensed tracks they may need to pay for.

THE DAILY QUIZ

Identify these personalities from their Wikipedia page subheadings

Mohammed Hidayat

- QUESTION 1**
Childhood - Public speaker - Pune Ashram - Arrival in the United States - 1984 bioterror attack.
- QUESTION 2**
Early life - Mathematics career - Life in Montana - Mail bombings - Manifesto.
- QUESTION 3**
Early life - Founding a blood-testing startup - Self-made female billionaire - Downfall - Fraud charges.
- QUESTION 4**
Early life - Career - Photography hobby - Later years - Death - Discovery and recognition - Legacy.
- QUESTION 5**
Early religious and political influences - Founding a new religious organisation - Relocation to a South American country - Mass murder-suicide.
- QUESTION 6**
Early life - Led own gang - Massacre - Surrender - Political career - Assassination.



Visual Question:
Identify the African leader and fill in the blank.
Early life - Rise in Army - Seizure of power - Expulsion of _____ - War with Tanzania - Exile - Death - Erratic behaviour, self-bestowed titles and media portrayal. AP

Questions and Answers to the previous day’s daily quiz:
1. What was the name of the feminist magazine she co-founded in 1971 which survives till today? **Ans: Ms. magazine**
2. Steinem said once that she had never wanted children because she already had one. Who was she referring to? **Ans: Her mother**
3. Steinem was part of the second wave of feminism. Name the book credited with launching this wave, written by Betty Friedan. **Ans: The Feminine Mystique**
4. In 2005, Steinem, Robin Morgan, and X co-founded an organisation that “works to make women visible and

powerful in the media.” Name X, an actor who starred in Klute and Coming Home. **Ans: Jane Fonda**
5. In a controversial op-ed, Steinem once defended a U.S. President, saying his behaviour with women may have been reckless, but did not meet the legal definition of sexual harassment or assault. Which President was she talking about? **Ans: Bill Clinton**
Visual: Where did she work, which led to her seminal 1963 undercover exposé, ‘A Bunny’s Tale’? **Ans: The Playboy Club**
Early Birds: Dodo Jayaditya | Prem Nath Tiwari | Rony S. Emmanuel | Sukdev Shet | Tamal Biswas



KNOW YOUR ENGLISH

Getting him to open up is like pulling teeth

Students urged to think rather than parrot textbook answers

S. Upendran

“It was good to see your mother after nearly three years. Will she be here for some time?”
“Maybe for another two weeks. She said that you’d put on weight.”
“She told me the same thing. I’ve been trying to lose weight for the past six months, but it’s like pulling teeth.”
“Pulling teeth? Getting one’s tooth pulled is not an enjoyable experience. Was my mom saying you’re going to have a problem losing weight?”
“The expression ‘pulling teeth’ has several different meanings – all of them negative. When you say that completing a task was like pulling teeth, it means it was a slow and painful process.”
“There were times when you just wanted to throw your hands into the air, and walk away!”
“That’s right! Trying to have a conversation with Renu was like pulling teeth.”
“How about this example? For many people, getting up early in the morning is like pulling teeth.”
“That’s a good example. My parents had a tough time waking me up when I was in school.”
“Talking about school. Unlike most people I know, you never talk about your school days. Getting information from you about your school days is like pulling teeth.”
“You’ll find that pulling teeth is a lot easier than getting me to talk about my school days.”
“In that case, I will stop asking questions related to that phase of your life.”
“Thank you. So, what’s been...”
“Tell me, what’s the difference between ‘aping someone’ and ‘parrotting someone’?”
“Tell me, what does a parrot do?”
“It flies around and”
“That’s not what I mean. When you talk to your pet parrot which has been with you for a while, what does it do?”
“When I say something, it sometimes repeats what I said.”
“Exactly! It repeats what you’ve said. Doesn’t really say anything new, does it?”
“It’s not capable of saying anything new.”
“Which is why the expression ‘to parrot someone’ carries with it the sense that it is mindless repetition...”
“In other words, when you parrot someone, you are saying things without really understanding what you’re saying.”
“Exactly! The Vice Principal parrots whatever the principal says.”
“My boss hates that. He doesn’t want anyone to merely parrot what he says.”
“Such people are difficult to find. Unlike his sister, Ravi is not very bright. He merely parrots everything she says.”
“So, now tell me, what does ‘ape someone’ mean?”
“When you ape someone, you mimic someone. In this case, what you do is to copy his mannerisms, style, the way of walking, talking, etc. And you do a very bad job of it.”
“We tried to ape our favourite rock band.”
“That sounds good. Children frequently ape their parents.”
“We all do that when we are very young.”
upendrankye@gmail.com

Word of the day

Shibboleth:
a favourite saying of a group, organisation, or individual
Synonyms: slogan, motto, idiom, tagline
Usage: *The phrase became a shibboleth among university students.*
Pronunciation: newsth.live/shibboleth
International Phonetic Alphabet: /ʃɪbəlθ/

For feedback and suggestions for Text & Context, please write to **letters@thehindu.co.in** with the subject ‘Text & Context’

CM
YK

‘If my party says I should step down as its president, I will’

It is not for the govt. or the BNP to decide who will lead the Awami League, former Bangladesh PM says as she calls for the ban on her party to be revoked; she asks how her press conference could damage India-Bangladesh relations, adding that her intention was simply to tell the truth; she has not met Modi or Sonia during her stay as she has ‘decided only to meet party workers and relatives’

INTERVIEW Sheikh Hasina

Suhasini Haidar
NEW DELHI

Defending her right to hold a press conference and meet her Awami League party colleagues while in India, Bangladesh’s former Prime Minister Sheikh Hasina says she has no intention of damaging India-Bangladesh ties. In an interview to *The Hindu*, including in written replies and an extensive telephone conversation, Ms. Hasina, who has been convicted of murder and sentenced to death in Bangladesh, says she is undeterred about returning to Bangladesh, and accuses the Tariq Rahman government of continuing to harass and imprison her party workers. Excerpts:

What can you tell us about the events of August 5, 2024, when you fled from Dhaka?

On August 5 (2024), I did not leave Bangladesh by choice. My security personnel, party leaders, and family members urged me to leave the Prime Minister’s residence. I was prepared to go to Tungipara [Ms. Hasina’s hometown], and I had expressed my willingness to leave and resign as Prime Minister. But I didn’t get the chance to resign.

I did not even know that I was leaving the country. Only when I was in the helicopter did I learn from my staff that I was being taken to India.

India received me at very short notice and made arrangements for my security and stay. I am grateful for that. But it was very hard for me to accept that I had been taken out of my own country.

When you reached Delhi on August 5, 2024, did you intend to stay in India, or was there a plan for you to travel elsewhere? Have you applied for asylum or visas in any other country?

No, I did not want to go anywhere else. I am next door to my country, as close as I can be to my people. From here, I can keep in touch with them. Where else would I go? How would I live somewhere else? I do not have any means to live abroad permanently.

Given your personal equations with them, have you met Prime Minister Narendra Modi or Sonia Gandhi during your time here?

Frankly, I did not want to try and meet them, given the circumstances. No doubt, I have good relations with them, but I decided I would only meet my party workers and relatives while here. Maybe a time will come that I will go home and then come again to India, and then meet everyone, including media.

Are you sure the Bangladesh government will allow you to go back, and not stop you at the border?



This is a peculiar situation. They repeatedly ask the Indian government to send me to Bangladesh, but when I say they don’t need to send me, I will come myself, then that also seems to be a problem for them.

The Bangladesh government says your recent press conference has damaged the atmosphere for India-Bangladesh relations. Do you think your public remarks are affecting bilateral ties?

When I heard this, I was surprised. How can a press conference damage India-

to damage anything. I wanted to tell the truth. Freedom of speech and expression is part of democracy. So, the real question is not whether my press conference damaged relations. The real question is why truth and free speech are being feared so much.

In your time as PM, you also banned the Jamaat-e-Islami. Was that a mistake? They are now the main Opposition in Bangladesh...

Bangladesh relations? I did not know that I was so powerful that one press conference of mine could damage Bangladesh’s foreign policy.

In 2007, Tarique Rahman gave a written undertaking that he would never engage in politics. But when he was in London and took up the BNP [Bangladesh Nationalist Party] leadership, he gave online speeches, held video conferences. Did my government write to the British government raising this issue? No. We did not ask another country to silence him.

My intention was never

with the Jamaat leadership...

If that is so, I have no comment.

Has the Indian government conveyed to you that you should not hold any more press conferences? What kind of support do you expect from India and the international community?

It is important for the world to understand what Bangladesh is going through today. The largest political party, the party that brought independence to Bangladesh, has been banned. My demands are simple. I ask the international community to support the lifting of the ban on the Awami League; the release of political detainees; the withdrawal of false cases; the safety and security of every citizen, especially women and girl children; freedom of movement; and freedom of speech and expression.

That was years ago. Today, even the Indian High Commission and the Foreign Secretary (Vikram Misri) have met

government were to revoke the ban on the Awami League on the condition that you step down as its president, would you agree?

If the Bangladesh

Awami League is the only party in Bangladesh that works according to a constitution. It is the party that decides who will be the leader. I am prepared to step down, but who is the government or the BNP to decide who will lead the Awami League?

How do you view the recent youth protests in India? Looking back, could your government have handled the protests in Bangladesh differently?

I will not comment on India’s internal matters. India is a democratic country, and its people and institutions will deal with their own issues. No matter how differently I would have handled [protesters in Bangladesh], their sole motive was to remove me. There was no compromise with them.



Jharkhand Minister and close Soren aide Sudiyya Kumar dies

Amit Bhelari
PATNA

Senior Jharkhand Mukti Morcha (JMM) leader and Minister Sudiyya Kumar died of cardiac arrest on Sunday. He was 56.

The two-time MLA for the Giridih constituency was serving as the Higher and Technical Education and Urban Development Minister, besides holding the portfolios of Tourism, Arts & Culture, and Sports and Youth Affairs.

Chief Minister Hemant Soren, in a post on X, said, “Late at night, I received the heartbreaking news of the passing of my elder brother, our beloved Sudiyya Kumar Sonu Ji. Accepting this news is extremely difficult for me. His departure has left a void in my life that cannot be expressed in words.”

“From the days of the Jharkhand movement, he stood with full devotion and strength alongside the late ‘Baba Dishom Guruji’ [late JMM patriarch Shibu Soren]. ...he devoted his entire life to the fight for Jharkhand’s identity, rights, and pride,” he said.

A close aide of Mr. Soren, Mr. Kumar played a key role in managing crises within the JMM, even during Mr. Soren’s arrest in 2024 in connection with an alleged land fraud and money laundering case.

Mr. Kumar returned to Jharkhand this week from Karnataka, where he led a State government delegation to explore ways to improve tourism infrastructure management and forest management.

Mr. Kumar is survived by his wife, two daughters, and a son.

CPI(M) identifies ‘parliamentary aberrations’, failure to follow mass line as key concerns

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

“Parliamentary aberrations”, failure in implementing the policy of mass line, and lack of collective functioning have been identified as the three primary shortcomings to be addressed as part of the CPI(M)’s “rectification campaign”, party general secretary M.A. Baby said on Sunday.

He was addressing a press conference at the conclusion of a two-day meeting of the party’s Polit Bureau in New Delhi. The “rectification campaign” comes in the wake of the party’s defeat in the Kerala Assembly election.

“The 24th Party Congress in Madurai had called for a stage-wise rectification campaign within the party. As part of implementing this, we had a discussion. Parliamentary aberrations, lack of adherence to the mass line by party comrades, and is-



CPI(M) general secretary M.A.Baby addresses the media after the party’s meeting in New Delhi on Sunday. SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP

sues related to collective functioning have been identified by the party. We have to discuss how far each one of us is free from these,” he said.

A Polit Bureau statement issued later said, “The impact of alien class influences like parliamentarism was discussed along with the experiences in implementing the policy of mass line and measures to strengthen collective functioning at all levels of the Party.”

Mr. Baby did not explain the phrase “parliamentary aberrations”, only stating that it has “various dimensions”. He elaborated at length on the need for a better connection with people. “We should be with people, learn from them and listen to them,” he said. He added that when the senior leadership visits States, it should take time out beyond formal committee meetings to speak to comrades and listen to them. Each State commit-

tee would undertake this rectification exercise, he said.

Former Keralam Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan, at recent public meetings in Payyannur and Taliparamba in Kannur, had blamed betrayal, internal sabotage and party workers’ susceptibility to propaganda for the party’s poor performance in these strongholds and elsewhere in the State.

‘Support party’s pick’

Mr. Baby supported Mr. Vijayan’s stance, saying that if the party decides on a candidate, all members must support that person. Any disagreements should have been raised within party forums, he said.

The Central Committee will meet in New Delhi from October 9 to 11 to discuss and strengthen the report after its deliberations.

On contesting the elections in Punjab and Uttar Pradesh, Mr. Baby said the CPI(M) would remain com-

mitted to its goal of defeating the BJP and its allies. Electoral strategies had not yet been finalised and would have to be worked out at the State level. “We will explore all possibilities, keeping this goal in mind, to defeat the BJP and its allies,” he said.

Asked about Rahul Gandhi as a possible Prime Minister, Mr. Baby said the question could be answered only after the next general election and that any speculation would be futile.

However, he added: “Naturally, the Leader of the Opposition has the right [to aspire to the position]. But we do not want to engage in an exercise of hypothesising. Our goal is that the fascist regime of the BJP/RSS should be removed from power. Last time we came close to it; if we had been more careful, this could have happened in the last election. We should not miss our chance now.”

Modi turned student event into political campaign: Kharage

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Congress president Mallikarjun Kharage on Sunday accused Prime Minister Narendra Modi of turning his interaction with students at Delhi University’s Shri Ram College of Commerce (SRCC) into a “political campaign” instead of engaging with questions on the youth and their future and education.

In a post on X, Mr. Kharage said the Prime Minister’s visit to SRCC was an opportunity for dialogue with the country’s youth but alleged that Mr. Modi chose to avoid their questions. He accused the Prime Minister of using labels for the Opposition to divert attention from the government’s failures. Referring to terms such as “Naraaz Phupha” (Angry



Mallikarjun Kharage

Uncle), “Dimagi Naxal”, “Urban Naxal,” “Khan Market Gang”, “Andolanjeevi” and “Parjeevi”, Mr. Kharage said the “adjectives keep changing”, but the government’s “anti-people policies do not change”.

“Outreach is only needed when you become out of reach,” Mr. Kharage said.

Mr. Kharage also invoked the Congress’s *Chhatron Ki Goonj* campaign, urging Mr. Modi to listen to the programme and find some solutions instead of “beating around the bush”.

BJP to go it alone in Bengal civic polls, no alliance with NCPI: Samik Bhattacharya

Shiv Sahay Singh
KOLKATA

West Bengal Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) president Samik Bhattacharya has ruled out any alliance with the Nationalist Citizens Party of India (NCPI) - a regional party with which 20 rebel Trinamool Congress (TMC) MPs have merged - in the upcoming civic polls in Kolkata and Howrah.

“NCPI is an ally of NDA. In West Bengal, BJP will go alone. We will secure two-thirds majority in Howrah and Kolkata civic bodies on our strength,” Mr. Bhattacharya told mediapersons.

NCPI stand

Over the past few days, the Bengal BJP president has been advocating that the party is not considering any alliance with NCPI,



West Bengal BJP president Samik Bhattacharya

even though a section of rebel TMC MPs have been advocating the same. NCPI MP Sudip Bandyopadhyay and Kakoli Ghosh Dastidar had said recently that their party would contest the KMC elections as a constituent of the NDA.

Mr. Bandyopadhyay said he had spoken to the BJP’s senior leaders who were okay with the tie-up with the NCPI, a proposal which the Bengal BJP chief seems

to reject. After the defeat of the TMC in the Assembly poll, 20 MPs of the ruling party left the Mamata Banerjee-led party and joined the little-known NCPI.

The civic polls are likely to be held after the Durga Puja holidays. The TMC has maintained control over the two municipal corporations for the past two decades till recently when the councillors resigned.

Warning to aspirants

Mr. Bhattacharya has also issued a warning to the ticket hopefuls in the civic polls. He clarified that holding a saffron flag does not guarantee an election ticket. This comes amid high expectations from internal party hopefuls and newly joined members after BJP’s victory in the 2026 Assembly election.

1.85 lakh names out of Manipur, Sikkim poll rolls after SIR

The Hindu Bureau
GUWAHATI

About 6.3% of names in Manipur and 11.2% in Sikkim have been removed from the electoral rolls during the special intensive revision (SIR) exercise. The final photo electoral rolls were published in both northeastern States on Sunday.

Before the SIR exercise began, Manipur had 20,93,076 voters, and Sikkim had 4,71,081. After the SIR, the names of 1.85 lakh voters - 1,32,456 in Manipur and 52,614 in Sikkim - have been deleted from the rolls. Manipur now has 19,60,620 eligible voters, while Sikkim has 4,18,467.

Before and during the SIR exercise, Manipur’s Kuki-Zo groups expressed fears that community members displaced after the ethnic conflict that erupted on May 3, 2023, would be deleted from the electoral rolls though the government sought to dispel such apprehensions.

More women voters

In Manipur, women voters (10,06,962) outnumber men (9,53,350), recording a gender ratio of 1,056 women for every 1,000 men electors. The State has 308 third-gender electors.

The draft electoral rolls published on July 5 had 19,34,399 electors.

Altogether, 96,985 claims and objections filed during the claims and objections period were processed for the final rolls. In addition, all forms received before July 5 were processed for final publication. “A total of 56,871 electors have been included, and a total of 30,650 electors have been deleted from the draft electoral roll,” said a statement from the office of the Chief Electoral Officer (CEO).



During the SIR, Kuki-Zo groups had said that those displaced by ethnic conflict could be struck out of the rolls. PTI

The CEO’s office said it received 19,34,399 of the total enumeration forms generated for the electors. Altogether, 1,58,677 electors whose enumeration forms were not received were excluded from the draft rolls. Of them, 72,473 were identified as shifted, 43,000 as deceased, 34,740 as absent, 7,394 as duplicate entries, and 1,070 under other categories.

The Sikkim CEO’s office in Gangtok said the State’s final electoral roll has 4,18,467 voters, after the deletion of 52,614 names.

The draft rolls released in July had 4,33,294 electors, of whom 3,61,159 or 83.35% were successfully mapped with their own or parents’ electoral details from the previous qualifying rolls or the last SIR. The remaining 72,135 electors (16.65%) could not be mapped, an official statement said.

‘Logical discrepancies’

Among the mapped electors, the Election Commission’s digital system identified 52,384 as having “logical discrepancies”.

The total number of electors deleted during the claims and objections process was 16,809.

The final roll includes 2,12,534 men voters, 2,05,931 women, and two from the third gender.

**TRANSMISSION CORPORATION OF ANDHRA PRADESH LIMITED**
(A Government of Andhra Pradesh Undertaking & An ISO 27001:2022 Certified Company)

NOTICE INVITING TENDER
The APTRANSCO invites bids online for Spec.No.PMM32-e-70/2026: Supply of 30 Nos. 220V, 100AH VRLA Battery banks and 28 Nos. 220V, 200AH VRLA Battery banks, Date & Time of availability of above tender: 09.09.2026 at 6:00PM. Website: www.tender.apecprocurement.gov.in. Contact No.CE/Transmission: 0866- 2429230. R.O.No.GMCC/APTRANSCO/127/26-27 Sd/- CHIEF ENGINEER/TRANSMISSION

INBRIEF



FPIs pull out ₹7,443 cr. from equities in first week of Sept.

After investing in Indian equities for two consecutive months, foreign investors turned net sellers in the first week of September, pulling out ₹7,443 crore as a rebound in crude oil prices, rising U.S. bond yields, and a firm dollar dented risk appetite. The outflow came after foreign portfolio investors (FPIs) infused ₹30,919 crore in August and ₹20,200 crore in July. Before that, they remained net sellers for four straight months from March to June. With the latest withdrawal, total outflow by foreign portfolio investors from Indian equities has climbed to ₹2.32 lakh crore so far in 2026, surpassing the ₹1.66 lakh crore withdrawn in 2025. PTI

Punjab police arrest man wanted in U.S. over fraud

A naturalised American citizen, who allegedly defrauded the U.S. government of at least \$600,000 and carried a bounty of \$1,15,000, was arrested by the Punjab Police in Jalandhar, officials said on Sunday. Manjeet Singh Bedi left the United States in April and reached India via Canada to evade the law. He was arrested two days ago in a fraud case registered in Rama Mandi, the police said. During questioning, the police learned that he had committed fraud in the U.S. and fled from there. The case in Jalandhar involved allegedly duping a person on the pretext of helping him go abroad. PTI

UN-backed map must reflect Indian position on J&K, Ladakh: govt.

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

India on Sunday said a United Nations-initiated proposed world map must depict the Union Territories of Jammu and Kashmir and Ladakh in accordance with the country's official map, and any "inaccurate" or "misleading" representation will be unacceptable.

New Delhi's assertion came two days after it voted in favour of a UN General Assembly resolution aimed at correcting the world map to promote a more accurate representation of continental landmasses. The resolution titled "Correct the Map: Rebalancing Global Cartographic Representation and Promoting Equitable Representation of the World's Regions, Particularly Africa" was adopted on Friday.

External Affairs Ministry spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal said India highlighted that the resolution does not constitute endorsement of any specific map, projection or depiction of national boundaries.

"India's sovereign territory, including the Union Territories of Jammu and Kashmir and Ladakh, must be depicted in accordance with India's official map. Any inaccurate or misleading depiction is unacceptable," he said.

"Our position on India's sovereignty and territorial integrity is clear, consistent and non-negotiable," he noted.

Mr. Jaiswal further said: "The resolution neither adopts nor authenticates any particular world map, nor does it address political cartography, including international boundaries, disputed territories or place name".

ISRO's role is by no means diminishing: space officials

Agency will remain the bedrock of the Indian space sector, says IN-SPACe chief Pawan Goenka amid concerns raised by ISRO staff associations over 'privatisation'; agency calls concerns 'baseless'

Jacob Koshy
NEW DELHI

The top brass of India's space establishment refuted suggestions that privatisation in the space sector threatened the workforce of the Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO).

The role of the ISRO was "by no means diminishing", said IN-SPACe chairman Pawan Kumar Goenka on Sunday, responding to a joint letter from nine ISRO employee associations seeking written clarification on whether the government intends to transfer the agency's launch-vehicle and satellite manufacturing to private firms. "There has been some misleading narrative in the media around the future role of ISRO. Let me say it unequivocally: ISRO's role is by no means diminishing. It will remain the bedrock of Indian space sector," Dr. Goenka said in a post on X.

The reforms that began in 2020, he said, were aimed at expanding India's overall space ecosystem,



with IN-SPACe authorising non-government participation and NewSpace India Limited (NSIL) commercialising mature capabilities.

Industry would increasingly manufacture and scale mature launch vehicles and satellites, he added, while ISRO would concentrate on advanced R&D, scientific and strategic missions, and infrastructure too complex for private developers – including the Bharatiya Antariksh Station by 2035 and an Indian crewed lunar mission by 2040. "The direction is not a smaller ISRO," he wrote.

Longer clarification
His post was followed by a longer clarification from ISRO, calling suggestions of

There has been misleading narrative... the direction is not a smaller ISRO. It is a larger Indian space ecosystem, with ISRO pushing the technological frontier.

PAWAN KUMAR GOENKA
IN-SPACe chairman

privatisation "completely baseless and incorrect" and stating that the agency would neither be privatised nor have its importance reduced. Transferring a mature technology, it said, did not amount to withdrawal from that domain; the shift was towards an "ISRO-led national space ecosystem", institutionalised through the Indian Space Policy 2023.

The agency said India now has over 450 space start-ups against a handful in 2020, and aims to grow its roughly \$8.4-billion space economy to \$44 billion by 2033. Ownership of critical national space infrastructure, it said, would remain with the government. The letter that prompted the responses

was dated September 4 and addressed to Dr. V. Narayanan, Secretary, Department of Space and Chairman, ISRO. Its signatories cited Dr. Goenka's public remarks on August 21 that ISRO would eventually not make or manufacture any launch vehicles.

Questions raised
They asked whether that position represented an approved Space Commission decision. They further asked what would happen to sanctioned strength and recruitment over the next five to 10 years, and whether the associations would be consulted before irreversible decisions.

Employees of the Department of Space are exempted from the statutory definition of "industry" and cannot form trade unions. They instead organise as service associations recognised under the Central Civil Services (Recognition of Service Associations) Rules, 1993. The letter was copied to the Confederation of Central Government Employees and Workers.

As yoga and Ayurveda become part of India's global health diplomacy, experts press for credible standards

Bindu Shajan Perappadan
T.C.A. Sharad Raghavan
NEW DELHI

Yoga and Ayurveda have moved beyond their traditional wellness identity and are increasingly becoming part of India's global health and diplomatic strategy, with the Centre seeking to expand their footprint through medical tourism, international education, practitioner mobility and trade agreements.

The shift is particularly evident in India's recent trade diplomacy. The India-Oman Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (CEPA), operationalised in June 2026, and the India-New Zealand Free Trade Agreement (FTA) contain dedicated provisions on health-related services and traditional medicine. These include measures to ease licensing, develop standards and facilitate the mobility of Ay-

urveda, Yoga and Naturopathy, Unani, Siddha, Sowa-Rigpa, and Homeopathy (AYUSH) practitioners and instructors.

New opportunity
The India-European Union FTA, signed in January 2026, goes further, allowing AYUSH practitioners to use their Indian qualifications in EU countries where no regulatory framework exists and providing for AYUSH wellness centres and clinics.

The agreements represent an attempt to transform AYUSH from being a cultural export to a formalised health and services opportunity.

The India-Oman CEPA contains what the government describes as its first comprehensive commitment on traditional medicine across all modes of supply, while the India-New Zealand FTA has a dedicated "health and tra-



The Centre issued 1,646 AYUSH visas to nationals from 75 countries between January 2024 and February 2025.

ditional medicine" annex covering AYUSH practices.

The New Zealand agreement also provides structured mobility pathways, including a dedicated visa quota for AYUSH practitioners. The government said the agreement would institutionalise cooperation in education, training, standards development and wellness services.

However, the diplomat-

ic push also raises questions about how far formal recognition and market access will translate into actual international demand.

Experts point to the need for credible standards, evidence, regulation, practitioner quality and patient safety if AYUSH is to establish itself in increasingly regulated global healthcare markets.

Senior officials in the Mi-

Road map ready to make India drug-free by 2029, says Shah

Press Trust of India
PANAJI



Amit Shah

Union Home Minister Amit Shah on Sunday said that the government has prepared a road map to make India drug-free by 2029, asserting that a drug-free youth population would lead to the goal of a *Viksit Bharat* by 2047.

The Centre has adopted a coordinated, nationwide strategy to dismantle the entire narcotics network, from drug trafficking to financing, while also focusing on rehabilitation, as part of its goal of achieving a "Drug-Free India" by 2029, Mr. Shah said at a press conference after chairing a high-level meeting on narcotics attended by Goa Chief Minister Pramod Sawant and officials of the Union Home Ministry and the State government.

Mr. Shah said that in 2019, a four-tier National Coordination Committee for Countering Drug Trafficking (NCORD) mechanism was created at the executive, State and district levels to ensure coordinated action against the drug menace in the country. "Dedicated Anti-Narcotics Task Forces [ANTFs] have been constituted in all

States and Union Territories, and local police have been linked with the national strategy."

He said a Joint Coordination Committee was also formed in 2019 to enable Central agencies and State governments to take joint decisions against major drug networks, their international connections and operational gaps.

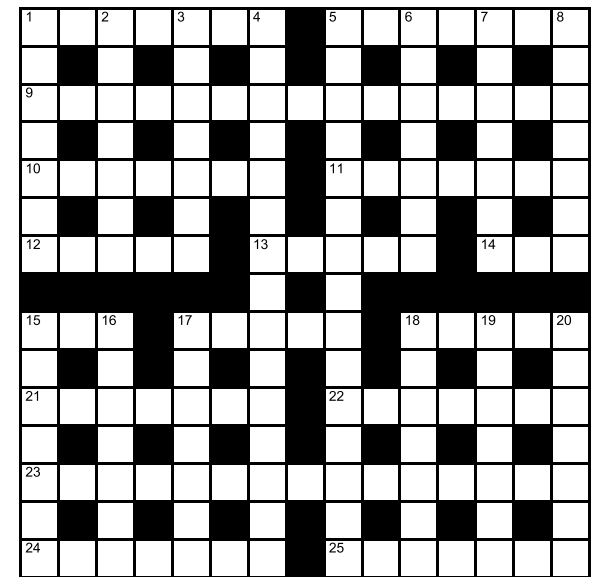
The Narcotics Control Bureau (NCB) has been strengthened by reorganising its cadre and enhancing its manpower, zonal presence and operational capabilities, Mr. Shah said.

The government has linked awareness, treatment, rehabilitation and livelihood opportunities with the anti-narcotics campaign, he pointed out, adding that the 1933 MANAS helpline has been introduced to support persons with drug addiction.

THE CROSSWORD+ 14892

Solve this puzzle online and access more puzzles at <https://thehindu.com/crosswords>

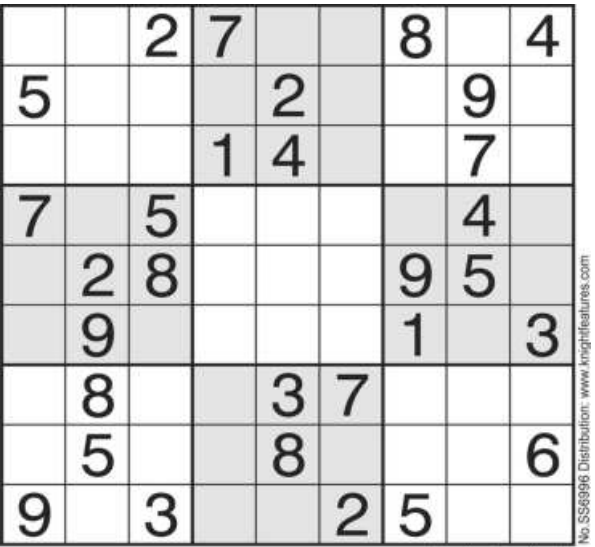
SCAN TO PLAY



- Across
- 1 Give me solicitor accepting Euros (4,3)
 - 5 First to finish, Italian gentleman passes over (7)
 - 9 Transformers communicate with this drunk Chilean man? Find out! (7,8)
 - 10 Guess working after retirement is hell! (7)
 - 11 A seed, it magically conceives (7)

- 12 Fish out millions for parlour (5)
 - 13 King's quality time wasted for a snake (5)
 - 14 Go bankrupt without one (3)
 - 15 Plant scents, ignored at times (3)
 - 17 Generous anchor going back to Sony at last! (5)
 - 18 Fellow with second-hand joint (5)
 - 21 Married Buddhist monk returns, enshrining eleven of the greatest values (7)
 - 22 Some hoodlum brag evokes resentment (7)
 - 23 Every bull and noble died foolishly in front of small golden-haired gals (8,7)
 - 24 Paramour loses head and fight's cut short! (7)
 - 25 Managed palace without slightest of tension or bitterness (7)
- Down
- 1 Silent dumb shows killing men and women with babies (7)
 - 2 Time to move with most comprehensive understanding (7)
 - 3 Working around extremely small letter (7)
 - 4 New Greek foe told about source of wisdom (4,2,9)
 - 5 Murg biryani name spreads - one's root! (9,6)
 - 6 No! No American eagle at court to disregard! (7)
 - 7 It generates power for player (7)
 - 8 Tramples kid of spouse from earlier marriage (7)
 - 15 Part-time expert's broken promise (7)
 - 16 Spooner's copy of document sent over net to a big plant without charge (3-4)
 - 17 Poets freshly rendered, possibly extemporised (7)
 - 18 When upset, Robin synthesises Spiderman's protein? (7)
 - 19 Love going into beach to shop every so often for devil (2-3-2)
 - 20 Doctor left out lower chest (7)

SUDOKU



Solution to previous puzzle

Solution to yesterday's Sudoku

FAITH

Rama answers Vaali

A dying Vaali questions Rama and wonders if He is indeed righteous. What was His enmity with Vaali? Why did He have to kill him, asks Vaali. Rama answers all the questions Vaali puts to Him, said Navalpakkam Vasudevachariar. Rama tells Vaali that Vaali had not cared for conventions or for uprightness. He had not consulted his intellectual superiors on the proper course of action, but had acted as he pleased. Rama points out to Vaali that everything on the earth is under the control of the Ikshvaku clan to which Rama belongs. Not only human beings, but even animals, birds and trees are under the control of this dynasty. One of Vaali's objections is as to what jurisdiction Rama has in punishing Vaali. This is Rama's reply to that objection.

Bharata is ruler of the earth and he is a king who never veers from the moral path. Rama has a duty to enforce rules in Bharata's kingdom. In fact, Rama says to Bharata that while Bharata will be king of people in his kingdom, Rama will be king of all forest dwelling beings. Having assumed this responsibility, he had to punish Vaali. Rama says there are three father figures in a man's life. One is, his biological father. The other two are his elder brother and his teacher. Therefore, that a man should be a father not only to his own son, but also to his younger brother and to his student. Since Vaali is the elder brother of Sugreeva, the latter is like a son to him. But Vaali has misbehaved with Sugreeva's wife. Is that not akin to misbehaving with a daughter-in-law? That is the primary reason for Rama to kill Vaali. How can he spare the life of someone who has sinned and has broken all rules? As the representative of Bharata, Rama cannot tolerate such conduct.

Balanced bond portfolio blueprint

Vaishali R. Venkat

It's always easy to buy a bond. A bond can 'promise' regular income but a well-built bond portfolio is a different ball game. It must be able to withstand a default, changing interest rates, and shifting economic conditions. A good portfolio ensures a single issuer's default does not wipe out a large chunk of your investment. The starting point is simple: ask yourself when and how much money you need, whether you want periodic interest or capital appreciation and how much risk you are willing to take: risk tolerance. The answers to these questions will decide the bonds you choose, the lock-in period and if at all you need bonds in the first place.

The spread
Don't let the bond portfolio turn a collection of similar bets. Mix Central and State government securities, Treasury bonds, corporate bonds and bank bonds, and spread the money across issuers, sectors and banks. Government debt can anchor the relatively safer end of the portfolio, while corporate bonds may offer higher yields with a mix of risk and return rather than depend on a single issuer.

Perpetual bonds
Stagger maturities rather than having all bonds mature at the same time. Perpetual bonds have no fixed maturity and can provide regular income but there is no predetermined date for repayment of the principal. They, therefore, need closer scrutiny and are not risk-free.

Interest structure
The interest structure can be diversified too. A portfolio can include zero-coupon bonds, bought at a discount, and pay no periodic interest; alongside fixed-rate, floating-rate and inflation-linked bonds. Convertible bonds offer another option: these hybrid instruments can be converted into a predetermined number of shares of the issuing company.

Credit rating
Before buying, credit rating must be the first warning signal. Higher-rated bonds such as AAA and AA usually carry lower credit risk than BBB, BB or lower-rated bonds. But a rating is no guarantee against loss; read the offer document and assess issuer before investing.

Rebalancing
A bond portfolio needs regular monitoring. Track interest payments, interest rate changes, RBI announcements, developments involving the issuers, and rebalance when allocation drifts from the original plan. Check whether interest payments are made on time, watch out for defaults and track credit ratings. If these alter the risk profile or portfolio's initial allocation, rebalance accordingly. Review it at least every six months or once a year. Finally, track the economy. Stay alert for major economic or political developments that might hit issuers. GDP growth, inflation, joblessness, CPI, WPI, Budget and sectoral performance can impact interest rates and bond prices. Follow these along with developments in Indian/global economy to help understand the forces affecting bond holdings.

No single bond, issuer, maturity or credit rating can suit every investor. The objective is to build a combination that matches need for income, capital protection, liquidity and risk. Remember, higher returns generally come with higher risks and even highly-rated debt is not entirely free from risk. Read the key offer document thoroughly, try to make sense of terms and conditions before investing in bonds. A disciplined approach can help ensure that bonds play their intended role. *(The writer is an NISM & CRISIL-certified Wealth Manager and certified in NISM's Research Analyst module)*

Send queries on personal finance and investing to the moneywise@thehindu.co.in ID. Our experts in personal finance will respond to select queries, but will not give specific recommendations for investment in a particular mutual fund, share or fixed deposit.



ILLUSTRATION: SAAI

Buying insurance at discount? Think twice

In insurance, the cheapest option is not necessarily the one that gives you the best value. Prudence here is not making assumptions but looking at both sides of the bargain.

BETWEEN THE LINES

K. Nitya Kalyani

Buying insurance is commendable. Being a prudent buyer of insurance is even better. That means more than bargaining for lower premium or looking for more benefits. Insurance is different from most products and services we buy. The price reflects the risks the insurer is taking and the cover and benefits offered. So, when you pay less it is worth asking: what, exactly, am I giving up? In the previous instalment, we saw how an insured, peeved at not getting a discount on a hospitalisation policy, decided not to renew. This meant losing accrued benefits and importantly, the cover itself. We all love discounts. There is nothing wrong with wanting the best value from a transaction. The problem arises when we focus on what we save without understanding what we may be giving up. Consider the experience of a neighbour. The owner of several vehicles, he bought a rugged beast of an SUV. He felt he had earned the right to ask his insurer for a concession. After all, he had been a client for a long time and had several vehicles insured with the company. The agent obliged with what appeared to be a handsome discount on the

You may be making a saving with a discount but always take a sharp look at what you are no longer getting for that saving

motor insurance premium. A good deal, or so it seemed. Until the SUV faced a dug-up highway, flipped over the median and had to be towed to the dealer's garage. That was when the discount got an entirely different meaning. The insured found the discounted premium came with a restriction on where the repairs could be done. Repairs at the manufacturer's authorised workshop were not covered under the terms of the discounted policy. Getting the repairs done at a non-network garage could mean delays in getting spare parts, concerns about workmanship and, potentially, implications for manufacturer warranties.

No free lunch
The premium had been reduced but so was the cover. While the restriction was stated in the policy document, the agent did not explicitly tell the client what the discount entailed. The point he missed was: it may be a perfectly legitimate discount, but it may not be a free lunch. As an aside, buying vehicle cover from the dealer

who also has an authorised garage is a win-win decision as said before in these columns. This way, the claim documentation, estimates, approval, repairs and cashless settlement will all take place seamlessly by the same or closely-related entities. I recalled a long-ago incident where a premium discount on a home fire policy resulted in the removal of flood cover. Chennai, as we know, is no stranger to floods, sometimes with tragic consequences. Luckily, since 2021, flood cover has been inbuilt with a single bundled premium following an IRDAI stipulation.

Claims too
While you have to be careful about discounts when buying or renewing insurance, claims can be fraught too. When a wind-shield breaks, the damage may be covered by motor insurance. But making a claim for a replacement, costing about ₹8,000, could mean no-claim bonus (NCB) is cut by one slab at least. With some insurers it disappears totally. If you had accumulated

the maximum NCB of 50% of the own-damage premium, losing it could mean paying substantially more at renewal. The claim may be admissible, but is it worth making? With most products, paying less means generally getting the same product at a better price if you manage to negotiate well. Insurance does not quite work that way. The premium is a price for a particular bundle of risks, conditions, exclusions and benefits. Change the bundle and the price can change too.

Knowing changes
Before accepting a lower premium, ask what has changed. Has an add-on been removed? Has a deductible been introduced or increased? Do you have co-pay now? Has a particular facility or service, like cashless claims, been restricted? Has the choice of repairer or hospital been limited? Has some other condition changed? You may be making a saving, but take a sharp look at what you are no longer getting for that saving. In insurance, the cheapest option is not necessarily the one that gives you the best value. Prudence here is not making assumptions but looking at both sides of the bargain. The discount may be real. The cost of the discount may simply show up later. *(The writer is a business journalist specialising in insurance & corporate history.)*

Gold and silver rise

PRECIOUSMETALS

Short-term trend in gold and silver have turned positive post the breakout of key resistance level; the trend would remain positive until the support level is breached

B.Krishnakumar

Breaking the downtrend of several months, precious metals recovered sharply in August. The expectations around interest rate hike by the U.S. Federal Reserve played a key role in influencing the prices. The weakening of the U.S. Dollar too helped precious metals stage a recovery in August. Comex gold gained 9.73 % in August to settle at \$4,497.3/ounce by month end. Comex silver posted an even better performance gaining 16.32% to settle at \$67.2/ounce.

Gain in local markets
Mirroring global market trend, the precious metal prices settled higher in the local markets too. The gains were, however curtailed by Indian Rupee strengthening against the U.S. Dollar. MCX Gold gained 7.75% to settle at ₹1,54,456/10 gm. MCX Silver, too, closed on strong note at ₹2,40,250/kg, a 8.46% gain last month. Comex gold price managed to breakout above the resistance level of \$4,410 mentioned last month. In line with last month's observation, the price later moved to the target zone of \$4,650-\$4,700. The short-term outlook for gold has turned positive and the price could head to the next target at \$4,750-\$4,800. The positive outlook for Comex gold would be under threat only if the price falls below the support at the \$4,200-\$4,220 zone. Until this zone is breached, expect the gold price to head to the target mentioned above. Similar to gold, Comex silver price, too, staged a breakout above the resistance level of \$66. The short-term outlook as a result has turned positive. The price could now head to the immediate target zone of \$72-\$74. The positive outlook would be valid as long as the price stays above the support level at \$62.5.

MCX gold price, too, crossed above resistance level at ₹1,49,000 and later scaled a high of ₹1,64,773 on August 24 before receding a bit in the past few days. The short-term outlook has turned positive and the price could head to ₹1,66,000-₹1,68,000 zone. The positive outlook would invalidate if the price drops below ₹1,48,000. Similar to gold, the trend in MCX silver price has turned positive after the price moved past the resistance level of ₹2,45,000. As long as the price stays above ₹2,25,000, the price could move to next target zone of ₹2,56,000-₹2,59,000. To summarise, the short-term trend in both gold and silver have turned positive post the breakout of key resistance level. The trend would remain positive until the support level mentioned above is breached. *(The author is a Chennai-based analyst/trader. Views, opinions in this column are based on an analysis of short-term price movement in gold and silver futures at COMEX & Multi Commodity Exchange of India. This is not a trading or investment advice.)*

Bank Fixed Deposit Rates

Bank Name	Interest Rates (%)			
	Highest Slab	1-year Tenure	3-year Tenure	5-year Tenure
Small Finance Banks				
AU Small Finance Bank	7.40	6.35	7.40	6.75
Equitas Small Finance Bank	8.00	7.10	7.10	7.00
ESAF Small Finance Bank	8.00	6.00	6.00	5.75
Jana Small Finance Bank	8.00	7.00	8.00	7.77
Shivalik Small Finance Bank	8.00	6.00	7.50	6.25
slice Small Finance Bank	7.75	6.25	7.50	7.00
Suryoday Small Finance Bank	8.25	7.25	7.25	8.25
Ujjivan Small Finance Bank	7.80	7.25	7.25	7.20
Utkarsh Small Finance Bank	8.10	6.00	7.50	7.00
Private Sector Banks				
Axis Bank	6.50	6.25	6.50	6.50
Bandhan Bank	7.45	7.00	7.25	5.85
City Union Bank	7.25	6.65	6.50	6.55
CSB Bank	7.10	5.00	5.75	5.75
DBS Bank	6.85	6.30	6.40	6.25
DCB Bank	7.50	6.90	7.00	7.50
Federal Bank	6.70	6.25	6.50	6.40
HDFC Bank	6.50	6.25	6.45	6.40
ICICI Bank	6.50	6.25	6.45	6.50
IDFC FIRST Bank	7.10	6.50	7.10	6.75
IndusInd Bank	7.00	6.75	7.00	6.65

Bank Name	Interest Rates (%)			
	Highest Slab	1-year Tenure	3-year Tenure	5-year Tenure
Jammu & Kashmir Bank				
IDBI Bank	6.50	6.20	6.35	6.25
Karnataka Bank	7.00	6.50	6.15	6.15
Kotak Mahindra Bank	6.80	6.35	6.40	6.25
RBL Bank	7.20	7.00	7.20	6.70
SBM Bank India	7.30	7.10	7.10	7.00
South Indian Bank	6.80	6.25	6.20	5.70
Tamilnad Mercantile Bank	7.25	6.80	6.70	6.70
YES Bank	7.25	6.65	7.00	6.75
Public Sector Banks				
Bank of Baroda	6.75	6.25	6.25	6.30
Bank of India	6.85	6.50	6.70	6.00
Bank of Maharashtra	6.65	6.40	5.25	5.00
Canara Bank	6.60	6.25	6.25	6.25
Central Bank of India	6.75	6.10	6.00	6.00
Indian Bank	6.65	6.10	6.05	6.00
Indian Overseas Bank	6.60	6.50	6.10	6.10
Punjab National Bank	6.60	6.25	6.30	6.35
Punjab & Sind Bank	6.85	5.85	5.85	5.95
State Bank of India	6.45	6.25	6.30	6.05
Union Bank of India	6.55	6.20	6.10	6.00

Home Loan Interest Rates

Name of Lender	Loan Amount (Rs.)		
	Upto 30 lakh	Above 30 lakh & upto 75 lakh	Above 75 lakh
(In %)			
Public Sector Banks			
Bank of Baroda	7.20-9.00	7.20-9.00	7.20-9.25
Bank of India	7.10-10.00	7.10-10.00	7.10-10.25
Bank of Maharashtra	7.00-9.90	7.00-9.90	7.00-9.90
Central Bank of India	7.10-9.15	7.10-9.15	7.10-9.15
Indian Bank	7.15-9.15	7.15-9.15	7.15-9.15
Indian Overseas Bank	7.20 #	7.20 #	7.20 #
Punjab and Sind Bank	7.35-10.75	7.35-10.75	7.35-10.75
Punjab National Bank	7.30-9.30	7.25-9.20	7.25-9.20
State Bank of India	7.25-8.55	7.25-8.55	7.25-8.55
UCO Bank*	7.15-9.25	7.15-9.25	7.15-9.25
Private Sector Banks			
Axis Bank	8.00-11.90	8.00-11.90	8.00 - 9.10
Bandhan Bank	8.55 - 13.52	8.55 - 13.52	8.55 - 13.52
City Union Bank	8.25-9.50	8.50-10.00	8.75-10.50
CSB Bank	8.30 #	8.30 #	8.30 #
Federal Bank	8.35 - 10.50	7.35 - 10.50	7.35 - 9.50
HDFC Bank	7.75 #	7.75 #	7.75 #
HSBC Bank	7.45 #	7.45 #	7.45 #
ICICI Bank	7.55 #	7.55 #	7.55 #

Name of Lender	Loan Amount (Rs.)		
	Upto 30 lakh	Above 30 lakh & upto 75 lakh	Above 75 lakh
(In %)			
Karnataka Bank			
Karur Vysya Bank	7.48- 11.80	7.48- 11.80	7.48- 11.80
Kotak Mahindra Bank	8.50-10.65	8.50-10.65	8.50-10.65
RBL Bank	7.60 #	7.60 #	7.60 #
South Indian Bank	9.00 #	9.00 #	9.00 #
Tamilnad Mercantile Bank	7.25 #	7.25 #	7.25 #
Housing Finance Companies (HFCs)			
Aditya Birla Capital	7.90 - 9.30	7.90 - 9.30	7.90 - 9.30
Bajaj Housing Finance	7.75 #	7.75 #	7.75 #
GIC Housing Finance	7.25 #	7.25 #	7.25 #
Godrej Housing Finance	8.20 #	8.20 #	8.20 #
ICICI Home Finance	7.65 #	7.65 #	7.65 #
LIC Housing Finance	7.50 #	7.50 #	7.50 #
PNB Housing Finance	7.15 #	7.15 #	7.15 #
Sammaan Capital	7.75-10.05%	7.60-10.05%	7.50-9.95
SMFG India Home Finance	8.75 #	8.75 #	8.75 #
Tata Capital	9.25 #	9.25 #	9.25 #
*Extra concession of 0.05% & 0.10% for women borrowers/takeover loans respectively Rates as on September 2 #onwards Source:Paisabazaar.com			

FAVOURITE VENUE

We always perform well at the China Masters, says Satwiksairaj



BADMINTON PHOTO

Playing here (at China Masters) is always good. After coming back from an injury, this has been a tournament that has given us a lot of confidence. In 2024, we played here after the Olympics and made the semifinal. We were not in a good shape last year, but we went till the final — Satwiksairaj Rankireddy.

EARLY EXITS

Yuki and Anirudh fail to clear first round in US Open doubles



FILE PHOTO

Yuki Bhambhani, right, and Anirudh Chandrasekar suffered first-round exits in men's doubles at the US Open on Saturday. Yuki and Kiwi Michael Venus went down to Americans Ryan Seggerman and Patrik Trhac 6-7(4), 6-7(3) while Anirudh and Belarusian Ivan Liutarevich lost 4-6, 7-5, 4-6 to Great Britain's Arthur Fery and Joshua Paris.

BIZARRE EXPERIENCE

I felt like I couldn't play tennis: Keys on her third-set implosion



GETTY IMAGES

I obviously got off to a really good lead, and then I got really scared, like I couldn't swing. I think she (Zheng Qinwen) started playing better: I started playing poorly. Then I felt like I couldn't play tennis anymore — Madison Keys after squandering a 5-0 lead in the decider to crash out of the US Open.

JOVIC'S TAKE

'We put on a show and it took everything to get through that'



REUTERS

Iva Jovic outlasted Alexandra Eala in an epic three-hour showdown at the US Open on Saturday. "The level was absolutely incredible. We put on a show and it took everything to get through that... losing my earrings, falling literally flat-out on the floor, ending with cuts on my knees, and suffering mental breakdowns," said Jovic.

Third time's the charm for Satwik-Chirag pair

The Indian combination, which had lost in the final of the 2023 and 2025 editions, produces a terrific comeback in the summit clash; it is ready to go 'all guns blazing' at the Asian Games



The band is back: Chirag and Satwik were slow off the blocks, but upped the ante in the crunch. BADMINTON PHOTO

CHINA MASTERS

Press Trust of India
SHENZHEN

The Indian men's doubles pair of Satwiksairaj Rankireddy and Chirag Shetty produced a stirring comeback to beat China's He Ji Ting and Ren Xiang Yu in a thriller and clinch the China Masters Super 750 title here on Sunday. Satwiksairaj and Chirag, who had finished runners-up in the 2023 and 2025 editions, fought their way to an 11-21, 21-13, 21-17 victory. The Indians bagged

their second title of the season, having earned the Singapore Open crown. The title is a big boost for the World No. 5 pair as it gears up to defend the gold medal at the Asian Games, scheduled in Japan from September 19. "It feels really special. Obviously, going into the Asian Games, winning a title definitely gives a huge boost. We are working in the right direction," Chirag said after the Indian combine won its 10th BWF World Tour crown. "I think we will go back home, push ourselves to the limit, train for the next 10 days and go all guns

blazing at the Asian Games. We want to go out there and have some fun." The Indians could not take early control of the rallies as He and Ren zoomed to a 5-0 lead with attacking strokes in short exchanges. He looked in ominous touch, raining down thunderous smashes, while a wide shot from Chirag allowed the Chinese pair to wrap up the opener. The Indian combination produced a far better show in the second game, tightening the defence and extending the rallies. Satwiksairaj also opted for a flick serve to keep the Chinese guessing and prevented

them from engaging in the front court often. The local hopefuls were behind 8-12 after losing a 45-shot rally, and the Indians stretched the summit clash into a decider with an attacking return from Satwiksairaj. Although the Chinese secured a four-point advantage, their opponents leveled the score at 7-7. Down by two points at the interval, Satwiksairaj and Chirag kept themselves within striking distance of He and Ren. After drawing parity at 16-all, the Indians had three match-point opportunities, the first of which Chirag took.

US OPEN

Agence France-Presse
NEW YORK

World No. 1 Aryna Sabalenka entered the US Open quarterfinals on Sunday, beating American Taylor Townsend 6-4, 6-3 to keep her bid for a rare three-peat alive. Sabalenka needed all of her resolve against the multi-faceted Townsend. The match opened with five breaks of serve before Sabalenka managed a comfortable hold for a 4-2 first-set lead.

The Belarusian star's sustained power and precision proved a little too much for Townsend. Sabalenka will face either sixth-seeded Wimbledon champion Linda Noskova of Czechia or 11th-seeded Ukrainian Marta Kostyuk for a place in the semifinals. Fourth-seeded Coco Gauff battled through in straight sets, and 18-year-old US compatriot Iva Jovic held off Philippines sensation Alexandra Eala in three sets to reach the last 16 on Saturday. Former champion Gauff beat Spain's Cristina Bucsa 6-3, 6-4, relying on her defensive skills as she climbed out of a 3-1 hole in the opening set. Gauff next takes on Jov-



Gritty win: Jovic edged out Eala in a three-setter. GETTY IMAGES

TOP RESULTS

Fourth round: Women:
1-Sabalenka bt Townsend (USA) 6-4, 6-3.
Third round: 5-Andreeva bt Bartunkova (Cze) 6-2, 7-6(5); 8-Swiatek (Pol) bt 25-Bouzokova (Cze) 7-6(3), 7-6(3).
4-Gauff (USA) bt Bucsa (Esp) 6-3, 6-4; 13-Osaka (Jpn) bt 23-Mertens (Bel) 6-3, 3-6, 7-5.
14-Jovic (USA) bt 17-Eala (Phi) 7-5, 3-6, 7-5; 2-Rybakina (Kaz) bt Starodubtseva (Ukr) 7-6(6), 6-3.
Men: 24-Cerundolo (Arg) bt

9-Fritz (USA) 3-6, 4-6, 6-3, 6-4, 6-4; 28-Blockx (Bel) bt 5-Cobolli (Ita) 6-7(4), 6-3, 6-0, 6-3.
Khachanov bt Bonzi (Fra) 6-3, 6-2, 6-4; 21-Darderi (Ita) bt Sweeny (Aus) 6-4, 6-3, 6-3.
Gea (Fra) bt Zheng (USA) 7-6(7), 3-6, 4-6, 6-3, 6-2.
van de Zandschulp (Ned) bt 31-Bergs (Bel) 3-6, 7-6(3), 4-6, 7-6(6), 6-3.
1-Zverev (Ger) bt 25-Tabilo (Chi) 6-2, 7-6(2), 6-2.
14-Tien (USA) bt 17-Mensik (Cze) 6-3, 1-6, 6-7(2), 6-3, 6-4.

der Zverev made short work of Chile's Alejandro Tabilo, winning 6-2, 7-6(2), 6-2. Zverev will meet Italian Luciano Darderi for a quarterfinal berth after the 21st seed beat Australian wild card Dane Sweeny 6-4, 6-3, 6-3. Fifth-seeded French Open finalist Flavio Cobolli of Italy fell to 21-year-old Alexander Blockx. Belgium's Blockx shocked Cobolli 6-7(4), 6-3, 6-0, 6-3, winning 11 straight games from 3-2 down in the second set. Blockx next faces Francisco Cerundolo, who rallied to upset ninth-seeded Taylor Fritz 3-6, 4-6, 6-3, 6-4, 6-4.

Arsenal delivers statement fightback; Barca coasts

EURO LEAGUES

Agence France-Presse
LONDON

Arsenal delivered an emphatic response to Chelsea's emergence as potential Premier League title contender with a 2-1 win that ended its rival's unbeaten start on Sunday. Mikel Arteta's side trailed to Morgan Rogers' second-minute goal but the champion showed why it is the firm favourite to retain the title with a blistering response. Kai Havertz bagged the equaliser midway through the first half and Martin Odegaard netted Arsenal's winner soon after the interval. Lamine Yamal struck twice for Barcelona as it demolished Valencia 5-0 on Sunday to maintain its 100% start in La Liga and move three points clear at the top. Fermin Lopez, Raphinha and Pedri were also on target for Hansi Flick's swaggering visitors on a hot afternoon on Spain's east coast. Defending champion Bayern Munich was held to a scoreless draw by pro-



Sealing it: Odegaard completes Arsenal's comeback with this smart finish. REUTERS

moted Schalke in the Bundesliga. The draw ended Bayern's run of 67 consecutive matchdays atop the Bundesliga table and was its first scoreless draw since February 2025. A last-gasp winner from Lautaro Martinez sealed a win for Inter Milan as the Serie A champion fought back from two goals down to edge visiting Napoli 3-2. **The results: Premier League:** Everton 2 (George 83, Maitland-Niles 90+6) drew with Manchester United 2 (Mbemue 46, Sesko 88); Arsenal 2 (Havertz 25, Odegaard 50) bt Chelsea 1 (Rogers 2).

LaLiga: Valencia 0 lost to Barcelona 5 (Yamal 6, 84, Lopez 22, Raphinha 50, Pedri 79). **Bundesliga:** Eintracht Frankfurt 1 (Burkardt 6) lost to Augsburg 4 (Ibrahimovic 46, Fellhauer 47, Claude Maurice 65, Rieder 89); Hamburg 0 lost to Mainz 5 (Becker 19, Mwene 41, Tietz 48, 83, Koenigsdoerffer 90+1). **On Saturday: Premier League:** Hull 0 drew with Aston Villa 0. **LaLiga:** Athletic Bilbao 3 (Nico Williams 46, Navarro 48, Sancet 90) bt Atletico Madrid 0. **Serie A:** Inter Milan 3 (Martinez 56, 90+1, Thuram 82) bt Napoli 2 (Politano 50, Hojlund 53); Roma 2 (Hermoso 89, Soule 90+3) bt Atalanta 1 (Ederson 47). **Bundesliga:** Schalke 0 drew with Bayern Munich 0.

GLOBAL CHESS LEAGUE

P.K. Ajith Kumar
BENGALURU

Magnus Carlsen rushing to his chessboard is not a very unusual sight. He was sporting a shy smile at his fans at Lalit Ashok on Sunday afternoon as he walked briskly towards the venue for Alpine APL Pipers' match against Ganges Grandmasters on day two of the Tech Mahindra Global Chess League. The World No. 1 from Norway was held to a draw by former World championship challenger Ian Nepomniachtchi. Carlsen, however, could afford to smile as his team won 11-6. It was the second victory in as many matches for the defending champion as the two Indians, K. Humpy and Vidit Gujrathi, scored full points — they were playing with black pieces — against Stavroula Tsolakidou and Leinier Dominguez Perez. Fyers American Gambits, playing at home, lost its first match after posting two wins on the opening day. Gambits were beaten



Mixed fortunes: Nepomniachtchi's effort against Carlsen eventually went in vain. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

7-9 by Grandmasters. The defeat of Javokhir Sindarov, the World No. 4 and the challenger for this year's World championship, to Nepomniachtchi proved costly. It was on time that the Uzbek lost. There was more disappointment for two-time title-winner Triveni Continental Kings as it went down to Cheq Mumba Masters 9-10. Kings have lost all their three matches while Masters could heave a sigh of relief after losing two, including one to PBG Alaskan Knights (6-11) earlier in the day. **The results: Ganges Grandmasters lost to Alpine APL Pipers 6-11** (Nepomniachtchi drew with

Carlsen; Aronian drew with Anish; Dominguez Perez lost to Vidit; Shuvalova bt Divya; Tsolakidou lost to Humpy; Murzin drew with Mendonca). **PBG Alaskan Knights bt Cheq Mumba Masters 11-6** (Anand drew with Vachier-Lagrave; Arjun bt Praneesh; Yagiz Kaan lost to Mamedyarov; Lagno drew with Harika; Batsiashvili bt Yip; Abhimanyu Mishra bt Daneshvar). **Ganges Grandmasters bt Fyers American Gambits 9-7** (Nepomniachtchi bt Sindarov; Aronian lost to Nihal; Dominguez Perez drew with Dubov; Shuvalova bt Bibisara; Tsolakidou drew with Khademalsharieh; Mendonca drew with Maurizzi). **Triveni Continental Kings lost to Cheq Mumba Masters 9-10** (Firouzja lost to Vachier-Lagrave; Wei drew with Praneesh; Aravindh lost to Mamedyarov; Zhu lost to Harika; Kosteniuk bt Yip; Pranav bt Daneshvar).

Olympiad crucial for Gukesh, says MVL

P.K. Ajith Kumar
BENGALURU

Maxime Vachier-Lagrave believes the Chess Olympiad in Samarkand could be crucial for D. Gukesh in the defence of his World title. The Chennai Grandmaster will be taking on Javokhir Sindarov in the championship match in Geneva later this year. The Olympiad, the ultimate World team event in chess, gets underway on September 15 in Uzbekistan, Sindarov's home country. "If Gukesh can capitalise on the confidence he has from his previous two Olympiads, in which he had excellent performances, and comes up with a great show again, he could suddenly go into the World championship in a much better mood," Vachier-Lagrave told *The Hindu*. "I think it would be very helpful for him if he gets a little bit of confidence back." MVL, as the Frenchman is known in chess circles, feels Gukesh needs a break to be at his best again. "He has been struggling a bit with his results, but he has also been experimenting and got maybe too much out of his comfort zone," the 35-year-old said. "He is



Vachier-Lagrave.
K. MURALI KUMAR

a formidable opponent. I remember some really good clashes with him." Sindarov may be viewed by many as the clear favourite, but there isn't any for Vachier-Lagrave. "You have two very strong young players who will be fighting it out," said Vachier-Lagrave, who is playing for Cheq Mumba Masters in the Global Chess League here. "At the last World championship, Gukesh was coming in really strong and Ding Liren looked like he couldn't play chess. But, suddenly Gukesh was under pressure." MVL has his own World championship to look forward to as he is part of the pilot edition of the newly launched Total Chess World Championship Tour.

INBRIEF



FIFA confirms Infantino will run in presidential election

Gianni Infantino will stand in March's FIFA presidential election despite the backlash over his now-abandoned plan to bring private investment into the World Cup. Football's global governing body made the confirmation on Sunday. "The FIFA president announced in April that he will stand for re-election in 2027," a FIFA spokesperson said. Infantino had declined to answer questions about his future as he arrived for the opening of the women's U-20 World Cup in Poland.

Mansi finishes runner-up at Indonesia Masters Super 100

Indian shuttler Mansi Singh finished runner-up at the Indonesia Masters Super 100 badminton after going down 16-21, 8-21 to China's Xu Wen Jing in the women's singles final in Jakarta on Sunday. The world No. 76 Indian had defeated Canada's Rachel Chan, while Xu beat third seed Anmol Kharb in the semifinals.

Skipper Kishan dons the lead role as East batters dominate proceedings

His unbeaten ton the highlight as the visitor reaches 385 for four; Abhimanyu, Sooryavanshi, Shikhar and Kushagra, too, punish South bowlers

DULEEP TROPHY FINAL

S. Dipak Ragav
CHENNAI

Ishan Kishan led from the front with a sprightly unbeaten 111 (135b, 14x4, 1x6) as East Zone amassed 385 for four against South Zone on the opening day of the Duleep Trophy final at the MAC Stadium here on Sunday. The Jharkhand batter built on the efforts of opener Abhimanyu Easwaran (72, 86b, 10x4, 1x6) and No. 3 Shikhar Mohan (85, 120b, 9x4, 3x6) after opting to bat.

While Kishan headlined the day, it was Vaibhav Sooryavanshi who hogged the limelight.

It is not often that you see packed stands for a domestic game in India. Yet, even before the first ball was bowled, the C, D,



Second nature: Kishan kept busy without trying to be aggressive. R. RAGU

and E stands at Chepauk were nearly full in anticipation of seeing the wunderkind. And in the first 90 minutes of the day, the youngster kept the fans on

their feet through some elegant strokeplay.

The 15-year-old got on his toes nicely to counter the bounce from the red-soil pitch and punched

South Zone pacers Mohammed Siraj and M.D. Nideesh to the off-side fence a few times.

And when Siraj went full, Sooryavanshi had no

second thoughts about lofting down the ground for a six and a four. The southpaw eventually holed out on the leg-side trying to pull C.V. Milind for 44.

At the other end, Abhimanyu kept pace with the youngster and did not hold himself back, be it pulling Siraj effortlessly or giving the charge to the spinners.

Post lunch, Shikhar and Kishan combined forces, adding 94 for the fourth wicket, capitalising on a below-par effort from the South bowlers.

Shikhar was largely untroubled, confidently driving Siraj for back-to-back boundaries through the off-side before launching off-spinner T. Vijay for a six and two boundaries off consecutive deliveries.

Kishan kept busy without trying to be aggressive, bringing up his half-century off 71 deliveries. In the final session, he pressed on

the accelerator and brought up his century in style, driving Shreyas Gopal down the ground majestically.

Alongside his Jharkhand teammate Kumar Kushagra (63 batting, 75b, 4x4, 5x6), the duo added an unbroken 144 runs for the fifth wicket as East established an early hold on the contest.

The scores: East Zone — 1st innings: Abhimanyu Easwaran run out 72, Vaibhav Sooryavanshi c sub (Tanay) b Milind 44, Shikhar Mohan b Milind 85, Sudip Kumar Gharami c Milind b Vijay 6, Ishan Kishan (batting) 111, Kumar Kushagra (batting) 63; Extras (nb-4): 4; Total (for four wkts. in 79 overs): 385.

Fall of wickets: 1-100, 2-133, 3-147, 4-241.

South Zone bowling: Siraj 14-1-96-0, Nidheesh 10-2-39-0, Vijay 22-3-114-1, Milind 13-1-56-2, Shreyas 19-3-77-0, Rasheed 1-0-3-0.

Toss: East.

A special hundred for Shreyas Gopal and a special effort from Shikhar

S. Dipak Ragav
CHENNAI

On a day when he made his 100th First Class appearance during the Duleep Trophy final, South Zone leggie Shreyas Gopal felt he was happy to prove a point that wrist-spinners can have a long career.

"I was told that there are not too many leg-spinners who have played 30-50 games. I wanted to show that leg-spinners can play red-ball cricket and still be successful. I put a lot of work into my bowling," said Shreyas on Sunday.

The 33-year-old had one of his best years in the Ranji Trophy last season, claiming 48 wickets and scoring 469 runs, playing a key role in Karnataka reaching the final.

"I think it's just tactically trying to get a little better. Using the crease, understanding the situation and when to attack, when to defend," he explained on the areas he has improved.



Pulling his weight: Shikhar made a fluent 85 on the opening day. R. RAGU

"Most times it would come off. Sometimes, like today, it won't come off. But as long as you go in with a plan, it actually gives you a sense of direc-

tion," he said.

Last year, Shreyas also led Mangaluru Dragons to title triumph in the Maharaja Trophy KSCA T20 tournament and felt his

time with M.S Dhoni at Chennai Super Kings helped him a lot.

"There are so many questions I've asked (Dhoni) over these last two years, and I just tried to take the whole thing over there. I wouldn't say we won because of that, but definitely some of those moves I wouldn't have made if I hadn't had that experience or that time with CSK," said Shreyas.

Meanwhile, East Zone batter Shikhar Mohan, who made a fine 85 on the opening day, was pleased that he could carry his good form from his maiden Ranji campaign last season where he made 613 runs.

"Coming into this match, I just wanted to carry that form from the Ranji Trophy. Ishan (Kishan) *bhaiya* gave me a lot of advice while I was batting. He was telling me which shots were on and which were not. Thanks to that, we had a great partnership," said Shikhar.

SHOOTING

Uthra Ganesan
BHOPAL

Going for his second Asian Games, 22-year-old Rudranksh Balasaheb Patil is a far cry from the teenager who took to the firing station in Hangzhou. It's been only three years but the period since then has seen the shy, nerdy and overthinking kid grow into a more assured, relaxed and quietly confident person.

"Excitement," he declared when asked what was the predominant feeling. The Indian pistol and rifle shooters have gathered here for a short preparatory camp starting Sunday before leaving on the 14th for Nagoya.

Rudranksh, the only Indian male shooter who will participate in two events, is not bothered with the responsibility, challenge or expectations of managing both.

The 10m air rifle and the



Motivated: Rudranksh says the aim is gold, and that his hunger to win is unabated. R.V. MOORTHY

50m 3 Position are completely different and come with their own set of challenges. Rudranksh, though, insists it isn't impossible. "I am getting to participate in two events and I am able to see that all the hard work which I have put in is paying off," he told *The Hindu*.

"This is the first Asian Games and fourth international competition in which I will compete in two events. Every time I have improved a little bit. I have

good coaches, good support staff. I am excited."

He missed out on a medal in the 10m by the barest of margins in a shoot-off with compatriot Aishwary Pratap Singh Tomar and is not hesitant to admit it hurt.

"Last time I came fourth in a shoot-off, I was really sad about that honestly. I don't want to experience that, I would like to improve my rank. Of course, the aim is gold. So there is a lot of motivation. The hun-

ger and greed is unabated. And I think my training is going decent, so let's see," he said.

He is also learning to understand his own body and to manage it, and his mind, between events. "I used to be at extremes back then; completely in or completely out.

"I would control myself at the moment something happened but once the event was over, I would be very sad or high-strung, wanting to keep winning at all costs. Now I am comparatively more in control," he said.

LIVE TELECAST

Duleep Trophy (final): Day 2, JioHotstar, 9.30 a.m.

Women's T20 Asia Cup: Sony Sports Ten 1 & LIV, 8 p.m.

US Open: SS Select 1, 2 & JioHotstar, 8.30 p.m., 4.30 a.m. (Tuesday)

Serie A: Unite8 Sports 1, 2 & Z5 App, 12.15 a.m. (Tuesday)

LaLiga: FanCode, 1 a.m. (Tuesday)

SNAPSHOTS

India qualifies for under-20 Asian Cup

TASKHENT: India qualified for the AFC under-20 Asian Cup after 20 years. The Blue Colts registered a 3-0 win over Bangladesh in their final Group B qualifier at the Do'stik Stadium on Sunday. Danny Meitei Laishram opened the scoring in the 25th minute before Vishal Yadav doubled India's advantage with an acrobatic finish on the hour mark.

Substitute Md Arbash then sealed the contest with a powerful strike in the 79th minute.

The victory took India to six points.

Uzbekistan's win over Syria later in the day ensured India finished second in Group B and qualified as one of the seven-best runners-up across the eight groups. Uzbekistan topped the group with nine points while Syria ended up third with a tally of three.

India junior men rally for a draw; women swamp Malaysia
MOQI (CHINA): The Indian men's hockey team



Danny Meitei scored the opener. X@INDIANFOOTBALL

showed tremendous grit to rally and secure a 3-3 draw against Japan in its second Pool A match of the Junior Asia Cup on Sunday.

The women's team, meanwhile, consolidated its position at the top of the points table with an 11-1 hammering of Malaysia in its Elite Pool match. In the women's match, India had as many as seven different players scoring with four goals from field play, five from penalty corners and two from penalty strokes.

The results:
Men: India 3 (Anmol Ekka 4, 60, Ashu Maurya 10) drew with Japan 3 (Ryushin Sasaki 11, Kazuki Nakanishi 48, 59).

Women: India 11 (Puja Sahoo 1, 42, Purnima Yadav 4, 17, Binima Dhan 8, Krishna Sharma 14, Sukhveer Kaur 21, Geeta Yadav 28, 53, Sanika Chandrakant Mane 43, 58) bt Malaysia 1 (Nur Mohd 38).

Messi creates both Miami goals in Atlanta draw

MIAMI: Lionel Messi set up both goals for Inter Miami as the Major League Soccer champion drew 2-2 with Atlanta United on Saturday in the Argentina star's first match since announcing his retirement from international football.

Modric available for Croatia in Nations League

ZAGREB: Croatia's veteran midfielder and captain Luka Modric will stay with the squad in the forthcoming Nations League matches, the national football federation said on Saturday. Modric, who will turn 41 on Wednesday, confirmed to coach Slaven Bilic and HNS head Marijan Kustic that he remains available to the Croatian national team.

Diamond League finals: Werro wins with a meet record

Agence France-Presse
BRUSSELS

In-form Swiss Audrey Werro was forced into a dip for victory in the 800m while newly minted World record holders Masai Russell and Alison dos Santos also raced to meet records on the second and final day of the Diamond League finals on Saturday.

Werro was pushed all the way by Femke Broeders-Bol.

Werro, 22, dipped for the line after a tight final 200 metres for victory in 1m 54.75s, one of eight meet records set during a high-octane night of track and field in the Belgian capital.

Russell delivered in the final 50 metres to win the 100m hurdles in 12.20s.

In the absence of Norway's Karsten Warholm, Dos Santos led from gun-to-tape in the men's 400m hurdles. The Brazilian timed 46.70s to obliterate the meet's previous best of 47.51 set by American Andre Phillips back in



Werro. REUTERS

1986. Two-time Olympic silver medallist Kenny Bednarek equalled his own world lead of 19.62s when winning the 200m – the American dominating a sprint in which reigning Olympic champion Letsile Tebogo of Botswana came fourth in 20.01.

And Jamaica's Tina Clayton wrapped up the 100m in 10.92s, with European champion Amy Hunt of Britain taking second ahead of American Sha'Carri Richardson.

China's Ziyi Yan dominated the women's javelin with a best of 68.42m be-

fore Jamaica's Rajindra Campbell set a National record of 23.08m, a world leading mark, in the men's shot put.

Italy's Andy Diaz Hernandez then went out to 17.74m in the triple jump before unbeaten Marileidy Paulino clocked 48.64s for a fourth trophy in the 400m to further re-write the King Baudouin stadium record books.

There was a shock in the women's 1,500m as Poland's Klaudia Kazimierska clocked a National record and world lead of 3:54.05, smashing Faith Kipyegon's meet record by a huge 0.70s.

American Hana Moll, 21, followed up on her victory in Zurich by improving by 1cm her personal best to 4.91m to win the pole vault.

Finally, Rumes Tharanga Pathirage wrote himself into the history books by becoming the first Sri Lankan to become a Diamond League champion by winning the men's javelin with a best of 89.04m.

Winfield should score an encore in Khammam Plate

HYDERABAD: The five-year-old mare Winfield, who won well in her last start, should score an encore in the Khammam Plate, the chief event of Monday's (Sept. 7) races.

1 CHAITANYA CHAKRAM PLATE (1,400m), (Terms) Maiden, 3-y-o only (Cat. II), 2.10 p.m.: 1. French Lieutenant (4) Antony Raj 56, 2. Mantle Plume (II) Akshay K 56, 3. Ashwa Jafna (7) Gaurav 54.5, 4. Belgium Waffle (8) Mohit 54.5, 5. Classy Touch (2) Neeraj 54.5, 6. Costa Mesa (5) Kuldeep Sr. 54.5, 7. Evansville (9) P. Sai K 54.5, 8. Khamagani (6) B. Nikhil 54.5, 9. Kinship (10) D.S. Deora 54.5, 10. Menlo Park (1) Abhay Singh 54.5 and 11. Night Whisper (3) A.A. Vikrant 54.5.

1. FRENCH LIEUTENANT, 2. ASHWA JAFFNA, 3. MANTLE PLUME

2 KHAMMAM PLATE (1,800m) (Terms), 3-y-o and upward, 2.45: 1. Gold Empire (4) A.A. Vikrant 61, 2. Truth (7) Imran Chisty 59, 3. Nonpareil (6) Akshay K 57.5, 4. Winfield (1) Antony Raj 55, 5. Get Lucky (8) Md. Ekram 53.5, 6. Shadow Of The Moon (2) Afroz K 53.5, 7. N R I Superpower (3) Ajay K 52 and 8. Secret Saint (5) Abhay Singh 52.

1. WINFIELD, 2. NONPAREIL, 3. GET LUCKY

3 MAHABUBNAGAR PLATE (Div. II) (1,200m), 5-y-o and upward, rated 60 to 85 (Cat. II), 3.20: 1. Viv-aldo (5) B. Nikhil 62, 2. Knight Crusader (4) B.R. Kumar 58, 3. Decoy (7) Shivam 57.5, 4. Darling's Boy (9) P. Ajeeth K 56, 5. Annhilator (6) Akshay K 55.5, 6. Azrinaz (3) A.A. Vikrant 55, 7. Star Forever (8) P. Sai K 55, 8. Detective (1) Gaurav 54, 9. Glorious Power (10) M.S. Deora 52.5 and 10. Torchbearer (2) Kuldeep Jr. 51.

1. ANNHILATOR, 2. KNIGHT CRUSADER, 3. DECOY

4 MANCHERIAL PLATE (1,600m), 5-y-o and upward, rated 20 to 45 (Cat. III), 3.55: 1. Bold Beauty (4) Md. Ismail 60.5, 2. Take A Breath (7) Rafique Sk. 60.5, 3. Sunny Day (2) P. Ajeeth K 59.5, 4. Only My Way (6) Afroz K 58, 5. Silver Arrow (8) A.A. Vikrant 58, 6. Hoping High (5) Mohit 53.5, 7. Secret Option (1) Akshay K 52.5 and 8. Shubhrak (3) Surya Prakash 52.

1. SECRET OPTION, 2. TAKE A BREATH, 3. HOPING HIGH

5 BHADRACHALAM TROPHY (1,200m), 3-y-o and upward, rated 40 to 65 (Cat. II), 4.30: 1. Dubai Touch (13) M.S. Deora 60, 2. Dyanoosh (6) Md. Ekram 59.5, 3. Warwick (3) P. Ajeeth K 59.5, 4. See The Light (II) B.R. Kumar 58.5, 5. Clara (12) Imran Chisty 57, 6. Kalki (10) Surya Prakash 56.5, 7. Pole Star (8) Akshay K 55, 8. Flying Fury (7) G. Nareesh 54, 9. Dashing Charm (5) Kuldeep Jr. 53.5, 10. Sangreal (2) P. Sai K 53.5, 11. Sharanga (9) Abhay Singh 53.5, 12. Colt Pistol (1) Rafique Sk. 51 and 13. Calabasas (4) Ajay K 50.5.

1. WARWICK, 2. SEE THE LIGHT, 3. POLE STAR

6 MAHABUBNAGAR PLATE (Div. II) (1,200m), 5-y-o and upward, rated 60 to 85 (Cat. II), 5.05: 1. Ragnark (3) Shivam 60, 2. Exclusive Black (10) Akshay K 58, 3. Victoria Doreasani (1) Mohit 57.5, 4. She Can (4) Santosh Raj 56.5, 5. Gloria (7) Antony Raj 56, 6. Calista girl (2) Kuldeep Jr. 55.5, 7. High Speed Dive (8) Rafique Sk. 54, 8. Dali's Destiny (5) D.S. Deora 53 and 10. Best Buddy (9) Md. Ekram 50.5.

1. GLORIA, 2. EXCLUSIVE BLACK, 3. VICTORIA DOREASANI
Day's Best: WINFIELD
Jackpot: 2, 3, 4, 5 & 6.
Mini Jackpot: 3, 4, 5, & 6.
Trebble: (i) 1, 2 & 3, (ii) 4, 5 & 6.
Tanala: All races.



The graceful artist’s brush with history

It was only fitting that Smriti’s record-breaking stroke, in India’s Asia Cup match against Hong Kong, came on the off-side. It was not just her former India captain that she moved ahead of on account of her 64-ball 124. She also took the record for the most hundreds in women’s international cricket from Australian legend Meg Lanning

P.K. Ajith Kumar

Smriti Mandhana danced down the track. She launched into Ruchitha Venkatesh, and sent the hapless off-spinner over wide long-off.

The six took her past fellow-Indian Mithali Raj, making her the leading scorer of runs in international women’s cricket.

It was only fitting that her record-breaking stroke, in India’s Asia Cup match against Hong Kong China at the Dubai International Cricket Stadium last Thursday, came on the off-side. She is, after all, the goddess on the off-side.

It was not just her former India captain that Smriti moved ahead of on account of her 64-ball 124. She also took the record for the most hundreds in women’s international cricket from Australian legend Meg Lanning, who retired at the age of 31, and South Africa captain Laura Wolvaardt (17 each).

Lanning and Mithali were the two outstanding batters in women’s cricket. Ian Bishop had once said, Lanning was one of the very few players, male or female, that he would stop whatever he was doing just to watch her bat. And she is regarded by many, including the great Charlotte Edwards, as the greatest female cricketer of all time.

But for Mithali, humble and amiable off the field and ruthless on it, girls like Smriti would not have had an idol to look up to in India.

Until a decade ago, Mithali was the main reason why people in the country were aware of the existence of women’s cricket in India. She would score big runs with remarkable regularity and force her way into the sports pages.

Women’s cricket in India may be big now with big money, but for a long time it was the runs of Mithali and the wickets of Jhulan Goswami, along with thankless efforts from their teammates and their predecessors as well as the sacrifices of a man called Mahendra Kumar Sharma (an organiser who sold his property so that he could fund women’s cricket), that kept the sport alive.

Mithali and Jhulan are a bit unlucky in that their careers ended a year before the WPL began. They deserved to be part of the most glamorous and lucrative league in women’s cricket.

Smriti has certainly been lucky. Or cricket fans have been lucky. The WPL has played a major role in widening the fanbase of women’s cricket considerably. So a lot more people have been able to enjoy the sheer artistry of Smriti’s batting.

Make no mistake, there is no one in women’s cricket that gives as much joy. Yes, Wolvaardt has her own fans, and her cover drive is perfection; it is one of the greatest sights in cricket. And yet, Smriti is in a league of her own. When she gets going, you know why sport, at the highest level, is able to compete with art. The thing with Smriti is that even when she isn’t at her best, she can look good enough.

One recalls her speaking at a press

K.R. DEEPAK



conference about how she felt she wasn’t exactly at her best, after playing a big knock and some lovely strokes. That was the perfectionist in her speaking. A real artist is like that.

While the artistry in her batting may be a gift, her phenomenal success is something she has worked hard for. When she was little, her mother asked her to reach the top of whatever activity she chose for herself. She followed that advice.

Look at the way she is getting better and better. She is scoring faster, and she is converting far better, too. She has of late been hitting more hundreds in international cricket than she used to: last year alone, she made six of them.

Breathtaking

One of those hundreds gave India an excellent chance of pulling off a most unlikely chase against Australia. The Aussie women had made 412, and that too, without even batting for the full 50 overs at New Delhi. That was 111 more than the successful chase in a Women’s ODI at the time (since then India and New Zealand have set new records).

That night in Delhi, Beth Mooney, with a brilliant 75-ball 138, seemed to have batted India out of the match, but Smriti was in no mood to go down without a fight. Her breathtaking 125 off 63 balls raised India’s hopes. One recalls, while watching the match from the media box, going back to the scorecard of that incredible men’s ODI between South Africa and Australia at Johannesburg in



brother Shravan, who played for the Maharashtra junior team, that she wanted to become a cricketer. Rahul Dravid had presented her a bat through him.

Smriti played with that bat during her India debut against Bangladesh in the final T20I at the Reliance Stadium in Vadodara in 2013. Later that year, in the same Gujarat city, she scored a stunning 224 off 150 balls for Maharashtra against Gujarat in a West Zone under-19 one-day game at the Alembic ground. That innings was one of the early signs of her extraordinary talent.

She was 17 then.

Thirteen years later, she holds two of the most significant all-time records in women’s cricket. In fact, after her record-breaking innings, she said: “It is just the start, I would say.”

She admitted: “Going past the international record of the centuries, I mean, 18 is a good number to go past, firstly I will say that. But again, two of the legends of women’s cricket, Meg Lanning and Mithali Raj. Genuinely, these are the two people who I have grown up watching a lot of my cricket, tried to take a lot of things from them as batters. So I am really happy that I could go past them in whatever way.”

Smriti will continue to spread happiness wherever she goes. Her batting is like that. Little wonder, her fans are spread across different countries, be it England or Australia. She is hugely popular in the leagues she plays there.

She has also earned a lot of respect from her peers or former stars. When they speak about the batters they enjoy watching, it is Smriti that they often talk about first.

Former England batter Mark Butcher and former Sri Lankan quick Ramesh Ratnayake have said Smriti reminded them of David Gower. W.V. Raman, former India opener who has also worked with her as the coach of the National team, has compared her to Sourav Ganguly.

Of course, Ganguly and Gower were among the most stylish players of their generations. At the moment, few batters could give the connoisseurs of cricket as much pleasure as Smriti.

At 30, there is plenty of cricket left in her yet. So the cricket fans can look forward to more delightful innings from her. She may be the world’s best batter, but that doesn’t mean that she cannot try to get better. During the Women’s T20 World Cup in England recently, when she had an opportunity to chat with former Australian opener Matthew Hayden, she sought tips on batting from him.

Smriti remains committed to her art as ever.

THE GIST

- While the artistry in her batting may be a gift, her phenomenal success is something she has worked hard for
- When she was little, her mother asked her to reach the top of whatever activity she chose for herself. She followed that advice
- Beth Mooney, with a brilliant 75-ball 138, seemed to have batted India out of the match in Delhi, but Smriti was in no mood to go down without a fight
- The stylish opener was batting as if she was in a dream. As long as she was at the wicket, the 413-run target was going to be reachable
- Smriti will continue to spread happiness wherever she goes. Her batting is like that. Little wonder, her fans are spread across different countries, be it England or Australia. She is hugely popular in the leagues she plays there

Sharpest pictures of sun’s surface reveal previously unseen whirlpools

In all pictures taken of the sun’s surface in the past century, the edges of its convection cells were blurred; for decades, solar physicists wondered if these edges were really frayed or if they could find more detail if they observed the cells using a more powerful telescope; new images have settled the debate

Shamim Haque Mondal

Scientists have used the world’s largest telescope to study the sun to capture the highest-resolution pictures yet of the sun’s surface, revealing small, violent plasma whirlpools moving across it.

The discovery could change how scientists understand the way energy and magnetic fields move through the sun’s atmosphere. These whirlpools seem like an efficient way to move energy and magnetic flux, and could also be responsible for braiding the sun’s magnetic fields at small scales.

Such braided fields are thought to store and release the energy that powers solar flares and other eruptions – and may help explain why the sun’s outer atmosphere is so unexpectedly hot.

The team’s findings were published in *Nature* on August 5.

Details on the edge

The part of the sun that we see is called the photosphere. This is a chaotic environment filled with a roiling mass of superheated plasma. The light we see on the earth is energy emitted by this plasma.

Astronomers have been taking pictures of the sun’s exterior for a long time, and they have always seen a beehive-like structure there. The cells in this structure are called convection cells. Each cell spans up to around 2,000 km – the distance from Mumbai to Guwahati – and lasts for 5-10 minutes before dissipating. The visible features of a convection cell are called granules. All these granules together form the outer visible layer of the sun.

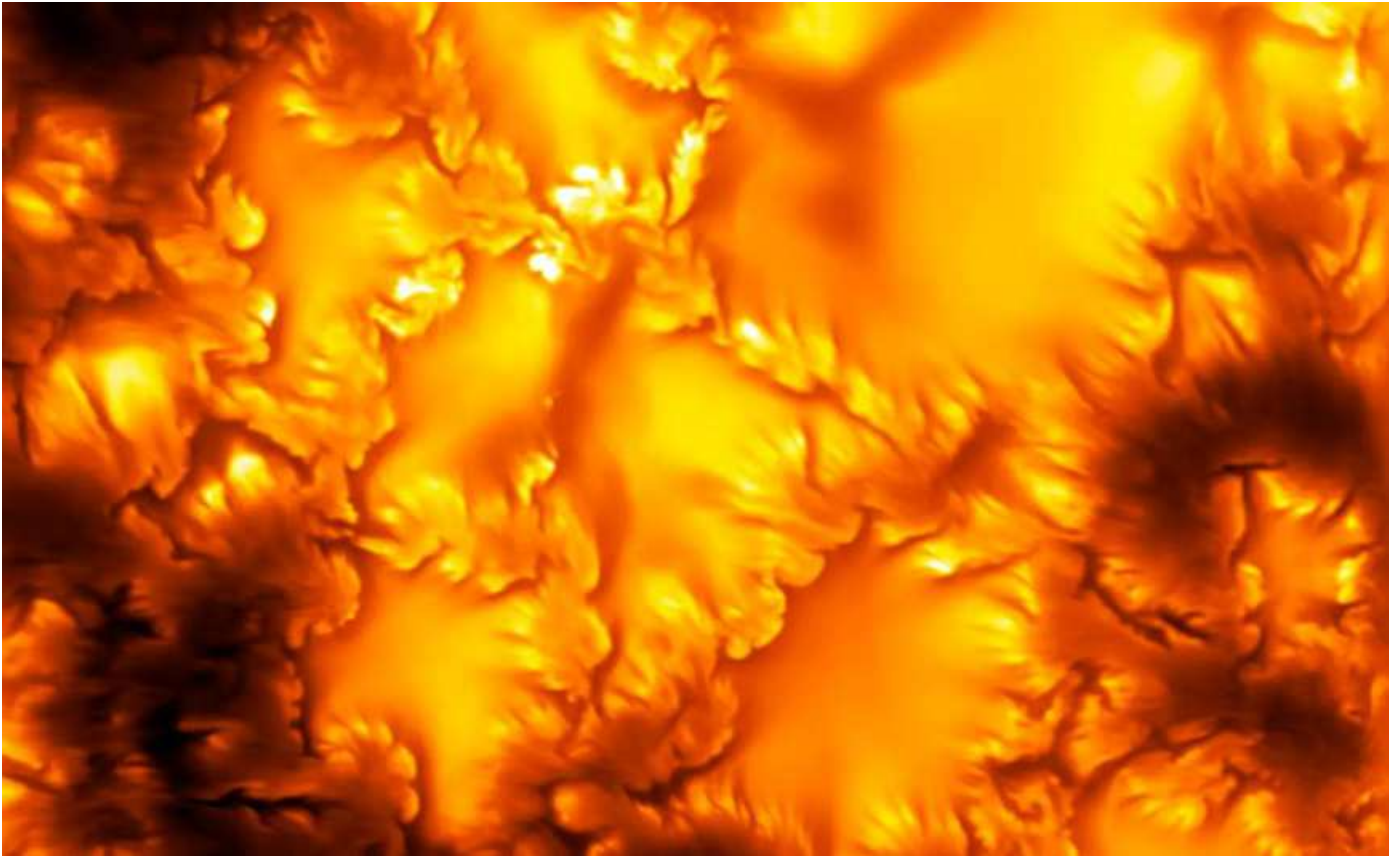
In all the pictures taken of the sun’s surface in the past century, the edges of these granules were blurred. They looked like frayed cotton.

And for decades, solar physicists have wondered if these edges are really frayed or if they will find more detail if they observe them using a more powerful telescope. The new images have settled the debate.

“The weakness is in the telescope’s aperture,” the researchers – from the U.S. National Science Foundation National Solar Observatory (NSO), Germany’s Max Planck Institute for Solar System Research (MPS), and the High Altitude Observatory (HAO) – wrote in their paper in *Nature*.

It seems that with telescopes whose primary mirrors are smaller than two metres wide, it is not possible for physicists to observe the fundamental perturbations on the sun’s surface.

For their study, the researchers turned to the NSF Daniel K. Inouye Solar Telescope (DKIST) in Hawaii. Perched



The highest-resolution image of the sun’s surface ever captured, by the Daniel K. Inouye Solar Telescope. At the edges of the solar granules, the image reveals fringed-looking structures that display swirling motions. NSF/NSO/AURA/MPS

near the 10,000-foot-high summit of the Haleakalā volcano, the DKIST features a giant four metres primary mirror. It started scientific operations in late 2019.

The team used it to observe a magnetically active region on the sun called NOAA 14060, capturing light at a wavelength of 416 nanometres (which is visible light of a blue-violet colour). They also paired the telescope with a high-speed FastCam camera developed jointly by NSO and MPS. The camera had a exposure time of 100 microseconds, capturing up to 740 frames per second.

With the help of this camera, the researchers took many pictures of the sun’s turbulent atmosphere.

Then, one member of the research team, Michiel van Noort of MPS, used an advanced image processing technology called multi-frame blind deconvolution to remove the blurring that occurs when the sun is photographed from the earth. Then the team combined multiple cleaned-up images to recover a clear image.

Dr. Noort used this technology to capture images of the sun’s surface of dimension 5,800 km x 4,350 km at a resolution of 19 km. This is like being able to spot a 10-rupee coin in Mumbai from Pune. Thus, the team found that the edges of the solar granules are innumerable small coils of plasma, each only 25-170 km long, separated by around

65 km. And they had their own little magnetic fields.

Wind over a river

The researchers also found that these small plasma coils moved along the boundaries of the granules, twisting and interacting with one another. And as they did, they generated whirlpools in the plasma – vortices that spun rapidly and changed shape within seconds.

When a strong wind blows over a calm river, small whirlpools form on the water. Generally, physicists say, a vortex is formed at the interface where two adjacent fluids move past each other at different speeds. The same thing has been found happening on the sun.

Scientists have previously found such whirlpools in the atmosphere of gaseous planets like Jupiter.

This is the first time scientists have seen such a wave moving on the surface of the sun.

These whirlpools in the sun’s plasma also rapidly grow in size. The scientists found that the fastest-growing vortices became 2.7-times larger than their original size in just 18 seconds. Even those that grew a little slower took only 71 seconds to reach this size. They rotated at about 1.6-2.8 km/s.

The scientists found that, over three minutes, these whirlpools constantly

form, merge with each other, and break up again.

A new way

The team confirmed its observations with the DKIST using magneto-hydrodynamics simulations on a computer. In both cases, the vortices’ rotational speed and energy were the same. In other words, these whirlpools are essentially the sun’s engines: they capture the sun’s internal magnetic energy and radiate it out into the universe.

The simulations also suggested the whirlpools lie 100-400 km below the photosphere.

The findings give solar physicists a new way to investigate the boundary between convection and magnetism. The whirlpools generate turbulence and continuously distort the magnetic fields. In doing so, they could provide the small-scale motion needed to braid magnetic field lines and release magnetic energy higher in the atmosphere.

The next step is to determine how much energy these instabilities transport and how the small vortices are connected to the more energetic events of the sun’s atmosphere.

(Shamim Haque Mondal is with the Physics Division, State Forensic Science Laboratory, Kolkata. shamimmondal709@gmail.com)

THE GIST

New images captured by the world’s largest telescope have provided the clearest view yet of the sun’s surface, helping scientists better understand how energy and magnetic fields move through its atmosphere

Scientists used the Daniel K. Inouye Solar Telescope in Hawaii, which has a giant four metres mirror, to capture the sharpest images of the sun’s surface; its advanced imaging capabilities allowed researchers to observe tiny solar features that smaller telescopes could not detect

Scientists found that tiny plasma coils on the sun’s surface continuously move, twist and interact, and create fast-spinning whirlpools similar to those formed when strong winds disturb water. These vortices grow rapidly, merge and break apart within seconds, revealing a highly dynamic process never before observed

BIG SHOT



In this drone photo released by the Geological Agency (Badan Geologi) of Indonesia’s Ministry of Energy and Mineral Resources, Mount Anak Krakatau spews volcanic smoke in Sunda Strait, Indonesia on September 5. AP

WHAT IS IT?

Sulphuric acid: not so deadly

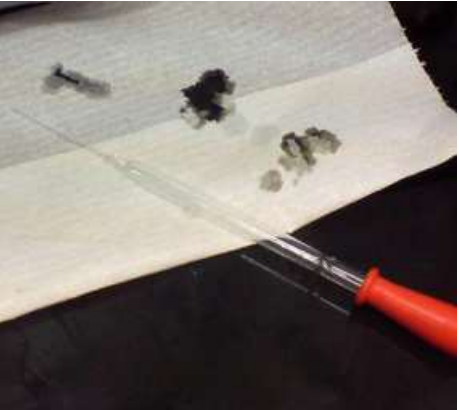
Vasudevan Mukunth

Researchers have found that certain peptides — short chains of amino acids that make up proteins — are not only stable in 98% concentrated sulphuric acid but also fold into the complex 3D shapes required to perform the functions central to life.

Thus, the findings, published *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences* on September 4, defy the assumption that concentrated sulphuric acid is a bane for the building blocks of life. Scientists had previously found nucleic acid bases and amino acids to be stable in the same solvent; this is the first time a macromolecule important to biology has been shown to be capable of the same feat.

Normally, strong acids break down peptides in a process called hydrolysis; as the name suggests, water molecules break down one or more important bonds. Since 98% sulphuric acid contains almost no water, the reaction that would normally shred the peptide bonds can’t happen, allowing the peptides to remain stable for several weeks at room temperature.

Using nuclear magnetic resonance spectroscopy, the researchers found that these peptides folded into a specific shape called an omega loop, using the sulphuric acid molecules themselves as a kind of scaffolding to help maintain the shape.



Drops of 98% concentrated sulphuric acid rapidly dehydrate tissue paper, leaving behind carbon, which stains it black. PUBLIC DOMAIN

This is however a significant departure from how proteins behave in water, where they typically form different structures like helices or sheets.

The findings are important for the search for life beyond the earth. For example, Venus is covered in clouds of concentrated sulphuric acid, which scientists previously assumed were too harsh an environment to host any complex chemistry. The new findings question this assumption.



For feedback and suggestions for ‘Science’, please write to **science@thehindu.co.in** with the subject ‘Daily page’